Scars and Tears (She's with Me Now)

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Scars and Tears (She's with Me Now)

by Xenakis (IceRosesCrown)

Summary

Who would believe that the feared Dark Lord, with her strict moral code, could actually have more heart than the ~~wicked~~ Queen of Mystacor?
Only a few people, and certainly not enough.
But maybe, just maybe, the young Princess can prove as much…

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Based on a writing prompt post which I kinda lost…

Notes

Immmmmportant note!!
The words you see underlined in the summary have the "abbreviation" html tag that lets you know who the heck I mean XD (just in case you didn't notice lol) Unfortunately, the function doesn't seem to work on mobile (pain!) so you'll have to read to figure it out :P

Also, I've decided to make this a gift to Series-Shipper who TECHNICALLY alfa-read this lol
And to xAsleepxForeverx because beta-reader, and help with a bit of an issue XD

Now yes, that's all :)

Chapter 1

Chapter Summary

It began with pain…

Chapter Notes

Alright, it's early in the morning, and my duties today start in a few minutes, BUT this draft was expiring tomorrow lol
I probably shouldn't have prepared it without a clear plan to start posting-

ANYWAYS
Uh, I hope you enjoy!! :D

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Footsteps echoed through the halls of the upper buildings; what was known as “the castle”.

People were frantically running up and down, and the clank of armour hinted at them being knights…

The kingdom of Mystacor always enjoyed blissful peace and hardly ever turned their sights to “the castle”, where the royal family lived.

The King was a silent man, the Queen, a loud woman, and the Princess… a role model. The Prince, on the other hand, had long left to Bright Moon, where he had married the angelic Queen.

Mystacor had always had this air of utter perfection… So when “the castle” stirred the slightest, the people *knew it*.

They didn’t know *what* was happening, but it was evident to everyone that it had to be something big.

Almost every acolyte expected the queen to make a statement, so they all gathered in the lower levels, muttered rumours running like wildfire as time passed without an official statement.

But they knew Queen Akane wouldn’t take much longer to appear.

And she finally did… around nightfall.

—Good evening, everyone— she began. —Let me begin by thanking you all for your interest and concern, but I am here to reassure you that there is *no reason* to fret. Home’s in order.

—Excuse us, Your Majesty— a man spoke up, the Head of the most important Guild of the kingdom. —If everything is in order, why are you only appearing *now*?

—Ah… Head Sorcerer Norwyn— she sighed. —I see you're sharp as ever— she laughed, hiding her annoyance. —Since you're so concerned, then I'll explain: everything *is* in order, yes, but I spent the whole day… taking care of my daughter who has fallen ill… I could only now leave her sleeping.

—Is that so?— he nodded, pensive. —Then why didn't the King…

—Enough, Head Sorcerer— Queen Akane interrupted him, her tone warning. —I advise you to measure your words, lest you incur in disrespect…

—Of course, Your Majesty— he nodded. —I just meant to say, if you had sent the King to let us know before, then we wouldn't have been so worried the whole day.

—Ah… Of course— she smiled, her look quite dangerous. —Then I apologize for misunderstanding and worrying all of you. But now, I must return to my daughter…

—Absolutely— Norwyn accepted, stepping back. —We hope she recovers soon.

With that, Akane returned to the upper levels, proud as always, walking with her head high and a severe expression darkening her face; behind her, the guards closed all doors and spread the order to keep "the castle" completely sealed.

No one should get in, *or out*.

Once the Queen arrived at her quarters, she finally let her shoulders fall.

—How did it go?

—How do you expect?— she barked back at her husband.

—Not good.

—That ram-head Norwyn began questioning everything!

—I told you to…

—No! Don't you even say it! Your useless guards…

—My "useless guards" shouldn't have had to be doing *that job* to begin with.

—Oh, don't start with that again…

—Akane…

—I'll take a bath— she interrupted him. —Find her.

Meanwhile, down in Mystacor's gardens, Head Sorcerer Norwyn walked back home.

He arrived exhausted, locked the door, and went to the backroom.

—I've returned… The Queen made it brief.

—What did she say?— a faint, female voice asked from somewhere he couldn't quite pin-point yet.

—Ah… That the Princess is sick— he replied, looking around the room, behind counters and inside closets. —She said she was taking care of her…

—And people bought that!?

—I tried to question her and she seemed ready to order my execution… I think no one believed her but wouldn't dare admit it— he nonchalantly replied, finally finding her hiding spot inside a crate. —Isn't it a bit tight in there?— he asked, opening it.

—It has been worse…— the woman sighed, hugging her legs against her chest.

—Please, come outside— he requested, offering the black-haired woman a hand to help her out.

—Fine…

Once she stepped outside the crate, he asked —So, have you eaten?

—And took a bath, yes, thank you— she replied. —I… wish I could repay you.

—No need— he denied, shaking his head. —Your trust is enough.

—I'm glad… but I can't stay.

—I imagined you'd say so.

—If I stay… and they find me…

—It'll be my execution for real, yes— he laughed. —But the good thing is: tonight, the Moons of Enchantment align. I can help you escape.

—Are you sure?

—Absolutely— he nodded. —The problem is… there aren't many places where you will be safe.

—I know I can't go to Bright Moon, but… some other kingdoms must…

—No other regent will protect you if your mother orders them to return you, Princess— he pointed out. —I apologize.

—You don't need to apologize…

—I must. There is only one place I am willing to send you to… and it's strikingly different from here. You're unlikely to find it pleasant, but I *promise you*, it is the only safe place.

—Head Sorcerer, trust me: anyplace is better— she insisted.

—Alright, then. I still recommend you… pick a new name. "Esmeralda" is a pretty unique name, and will likely have you brought back before you know it…

—I'm aware— she nodded. —I have one in mind already.

—Then get ready. We're leaving soon.

Queen Akane was never a good sorceress… But her daughter? She was very studious. Maybe not prodigious like her brother, but she certainly knew more than him.

So the woman had always been extremely resentful of Norwyn, their teacher.

She had him under vigilance for the longest time, and there was nothing she wished more than to catch him doing *anything* remotely punishable.

That night was finally the night.

—Your Majesty— a knight saluted her. —We've found her. Head Sorcerer Norwyn is taking a woman who looks like the Princess to the Lunarium…

—Wha- Wait. "Looks like"?

—We can't confirm it's her…

—If it isn't her, we'll have a bigger problem in our hands…— Akane considered. —No, no. I want you to send just a small squad to get her back and catch Norwyn. Only if it's her can we make it public— she nodded.

—Right away, Your Majesty— the knight saluted, before retiring.

As soon as they were gone, the King walked in.

—You're sending knights to retrieve our daughter!?

—What else do you expect!?

—Why didn't you- I-I could have gone myself! *We* could have gone to get her back!

The Queen gave him a shocked look for exactly a second before realizing it.

—You don't… Oh, my innocent husband…— she laughed. —Esmeralda *escaped*.

—Ye-yes, but… she's just being rebellious…

—No, no. She's being a brat, yes, but she has *no intentions to return*.

—Why would she…

—Are you joking? I'm not in the mood for that…

—No, why would I be joking!?

—Ah… Come with me, my Dear. We'll have dinner and then receive Esmeralda back once your knights get her.

Meanwhile, at the Lunarium, Norwyn and the Princess walked in, pretending it was his routine moon-alignment ritual…

—We won't have much time before someone notices what I'm actually doing— he began, speaking in hushed tones. —I'll open the portal just enough time for you to get through, and I'll get you as close to the castle as possible… But…

—It's alright. I'll figure it out myself— she assured him.

—Then let's get started— Norwyn nodded. —Stay vigilant while I draw the spell.

She immediately nodded and positioned herself between the entrance of the Lunarium and the Head Sorcerer.

She could feel her heart beating fast.

Too fast.

She was so scared.

This was her only chance.

And she knew… there was little hope for her.

So it was no surprise when her worst fear materialized at the entrance.

—Knights!— she yelled, warning Norwyn.

—Quick! Jump through here!— he ordered, immediately activating the spell.

—Follow me!— she begged, lifting a shield between them and the approaching knights.

—I can't— he denied. —Forget about me. Drop the shield and *leave*.

—But…

—Please, Your Majesty— he begged, raising his voice over the sound of clattering armour. —This won't last much more.

She had no other choice.

But still, she pushed her shield away as much as possible, delaying the knights a bit before dropping it. Then, she nodded at him, and jumped…

But not before a pair of arrows caught her.

The last she heard before the portal closed, were Norwyn's cries as he realized she got hit.

When the Head Sorcerer woke up, he was behind bars, his neck wrapped by a metal collar attached to the wall.

—You're awake…— a familiar voice said.

—Akane…— he growled.

—It's *Queen* Akane for you!

—I have no respect left for you!— he spat. —You killed your daughter!

—I did no such thing! If she's dead, that's *your* fault. I tried to keep her here and you sent her… where!?

—You don't… know? Those knights you sent for her… they *shot her*. Right before she crossed the portal. *You killed her*.

—You're *lying*! And you will tell me where you sent her!— Akane insisted, eye twitching.

—I won't.

—Then I'll have to pry that information from you… one way or another— she scoffed. —I hope you aren't too fond of those horns…

That night was quite cold in The Fright Zone.

Shadow Weaver had come to notice it always was when the Moons of Enchantment aligned.

But then again… she liked the cold. And the snow that would *always* fall during the alignment.

It was some sort of message from Norwyn, wasn't it? He had no need, but always made it snow over her…

A reminder, maybe? Of what?

The old ram was quite silly sometimes, so it could be anything…

He was, after all, the last friend the Dark Lord had.

The only one who refused to call her by that title, too…

Shadow Weaver was so lost in memories she almost missed it though: there was no snow that night.

It should have started already.

—Maybe he forgot the alignment was today and got drunk…— she told herself, trying to ignore the spark of fear that lit inside her.

However, one of her few subjects soon arrived, carrying news.

—I apologize, My Lord, but…

—Forget the apologies and speak.

—Someone appeared.

—Appeared?— Shadow Weaver repeated. —Through a portal? Out of thin air? Walking?

—Thro-through a portal.

—A tall old ram?

—No-no… A-a young woman.

What?

—Alright. Tell me everything now.

—They are bringing her in now…

—I need you to tell me *everything* that happened— Shadow Weaver insisted.

—Yes, My Lord. Sorry, My Lord— the stammering subject nodded. —There was a portal, near the entrance of the citadel. The-the woman jumped through, but… there-there were… some arrows on her back. Three of us intercepted her when we noticed she could still move, she was… trying to get to the gates.

—Did she say anything?

—She said her name is Castaspella… A-and before she could tell us where she came from, she passed out.

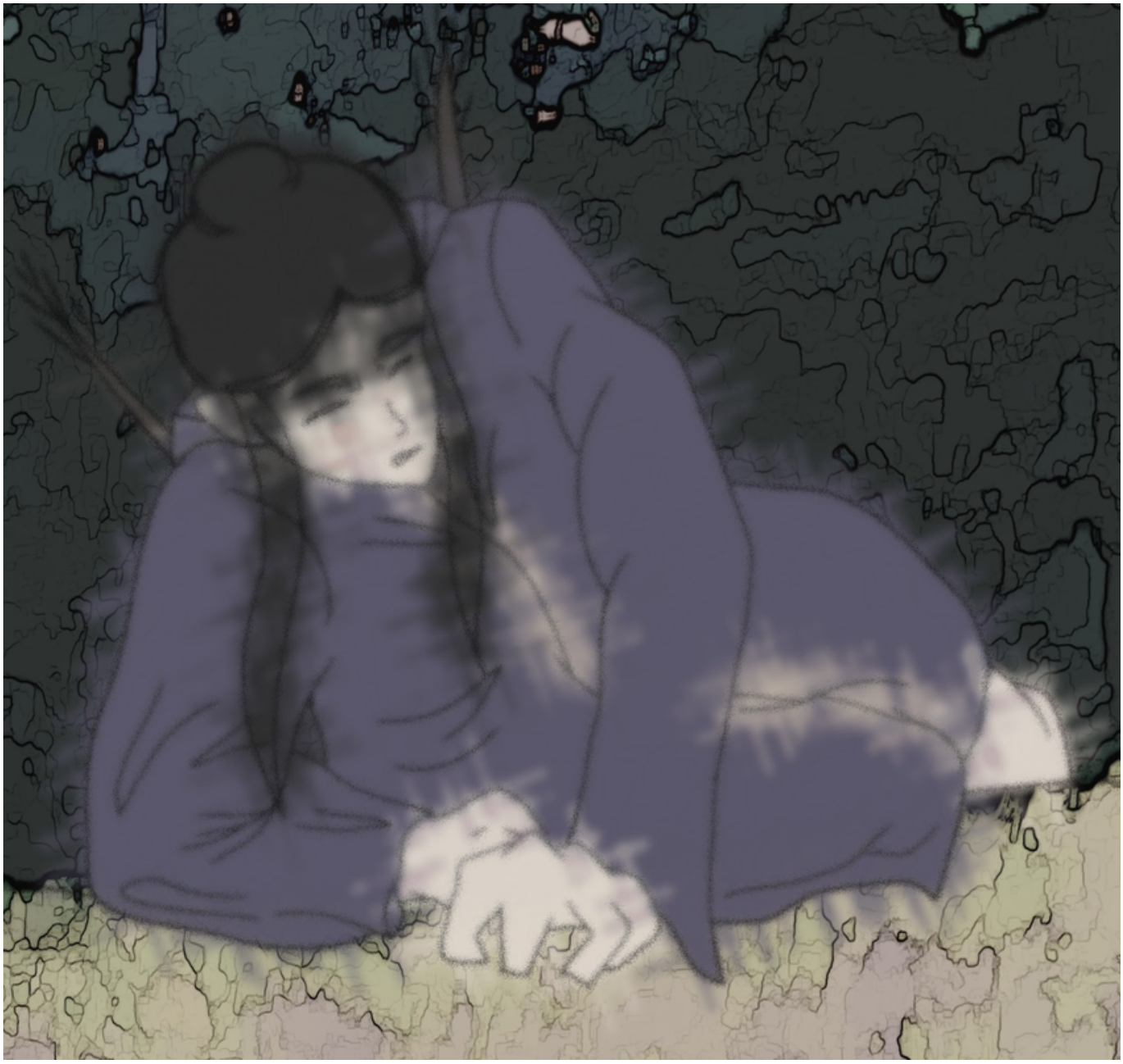
—Blood-loss, I reckon.

—Yes, My Lord. So we thought.

—And you decided to bring her inside, because…?

—Was it… wrong?

—No— she smirked, mocking the poor guy. —I'll handle it from here. You're dismissed.



Chapter End Notes

And so it begins!!

You've met my OC, Queen Akane, who's appeared before in another fic (with the alternative name Celia), and yes, if you think she has SW's personality, you're not wrong
But in this universe, SW has *a friend* (wild, I know), and thanks to him, she's nothing like in canon <("^_^) well, just a tad bit different, maybe…

IN ANY CASE, I hope you like how this is starting, and of course I will be updating weekly!! :D

I have… another 9 chapters ready, aprox… And hopefully this ends in 12 chapters and no more (/v\) Ehe

Anyways, see ya!! Thanks for reading!!

Chapter 2

Chapter Summary

Then healing came...

Chapter Notes

Hi! Thank you for returning to read this XD
We continue today this story, and, uh, I swear I love Casta, I dont want her to suffer (/v\) everything's for plot's sake!! (>v<)

Haha, anyways, I hope you enjoy and see you at the end notes!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The Princess woke up feeling dizzy, with a blinding light on her eyes.

Immense pain made her back feel on fire, and her throat was so dry it hurt her to swallow.

She wanted to speak, sit up, something… But not only she couldn't move, she also couldn't let out more than choked whines.

It made her increasingly desperate, her breath became shallow…

She wished to be dead…

She felt increasingly desperate; nothing but a mess of painful feelings overwhelmed her.

Until a cold hand wrapped around her right wrist and anchored her.

The mess found and order almost immediately.

Then a voice commanded —Calm down.

Right after, a different voice said —Here, My Lord.

Only then did that cold hand released her.

—You can't move yet, but you need to take this medicine. I'll help you drink— the commanding voice explained.

The cold hand's touch returned, on the back of her head now, lifted it just enough, and something that felt like wood was pressed against her lips.

The Princess didn’t resist and slowly drank the liquid.

It was warm, a bit thick like syrup, and fortunately had no taste.

With it, the dryness and pain in her throat finally receded, leaving just her back burning.

But it wasn’t that bad…

—Who…— she uttered, as soon as she was laid back again.

—Don’t speak yet. You lost too much blood.

—The arrows…

—I told you not to speak— the voice insisted.

It was a woman, wasn’t it?

—But…

—Enough. You’re still blind, aren’t you?— she asked. As the Princess nodded, she sighed —So I thought… The medicine will take effect soon. Rest.

Unable to move on her own, the Princess could only hear the mysterious woman walk away, and eventually surrendered to sleep once more.

Shadow Weaver returned to her room with a folder in hand.

The physician’s report.

She had an idea of what it could say, but she wanted to be thorough.

No one ever entered her Kingdom, people only *returned*.

So having someone, whom she couldn’t recognize, not only show up in her land, but also through a portal, and so heavily wounded… well, it was natural to have many questions.

However, the more she read the report, the greater her confusion grew.

This woman… she couldn’t be even thirty yet… And she was *so hurt*!?

The arrow-wounds were barely the more recent ones she had.

But the report spoke about so many scars, so many marks of past physical trauma…

Physical abuse.

Who was she and where did she come from!?

Back in Mystacor, it had been a whole day since the Princess escaped and the Head Sorcerer was caught, but no one knew a thing yet.

After all, who could hear the screams of the ram from outside “the castle”?

No one… The knights made sure.

And, as far as the public was concerned, the Queen still insisted that her daughter was indisposed and could not attend the programmed events and ceremonies…

The King, however, was starting to ask more questions, and eventually, he found the Head Sorcerer imprisoned.

—Norwyn!?

—Your… Majesty?— he barely managed to utter.

He didn’t need to see the poor sorcerer to know he was in bad shape.

—Why are you- You’re hurt!

—You… must leave… Your Majesty— Norwyn tried to warn him.

But it was too late already.

—My, my… Dear husband of mine, what are you doing here?— Queen Akane asked, revealing herself.

—Why is he here!? What did you do to him!?

—Don’t you know? This traitor sent our child to another kingdom, far from here, and won’t tell us where!

—You… got her… killed!— Norwyn tried to yell.

—What does he mean?

—Lies, my Love— Akane insisted. Taking him by the shoulders, despite him insistently looking back at the cell, she walked him away while saying —Come with me, we should have dinner and I’ll explain everything to you…

The young woman woke up only the following day, around noon.

A day and a half asleep, but finally she could stand the pain.

—Where… am I?— she muttered, as her sight finally focused. Then, she remembered that cold hand and the medicine… The *voice*. Had she imagined that? —Everything hurts…— she sighed, breathless. —Hello?— she then called, as trying to get up from the small bed she was in proved futile.

—Oh, you’re awake— a short man noticed. —I’ll get the physician, wait here.

—Thank… you— she let out, surprised as he left before she could finish thanking him.

She was left alone for no more than a minute.

Soon enough, a tall, blond man walked in, his eyes covered with a blindfold.

—Feeling any better?

—Barely.

—But you can sit, right?— he then asked, reaching the side of the bed. —I need to know if you can move.

—Hardly…

—I understand— he nodded. —Bring me the wooden box from the cupboard, please— he then requested, apparently talking to the short man, but not looking back at him.

He definitely was blind.

—Here.

—Thank you— the physician replied, reaching for the box as if he *knew* where it was without needing to see it. —Bring the Dark Lord, will you? She wanted to speak to her.

—The Dark Lord!? Whe-where am I?

—You're in The Fright Zone.

—This… place…— she began, looking around at the brightly lit infirmary. —I never thought this place was… Why was I healed?

—You were found in bad condition outside the citadel— he replied, expertly mixing some contents from the box inside a mortar. —I checked all your wounds, and it's… concerning.

—You… wait- How can you…

—I am blind, yes, but I am also a sorcerer and have *other* ways to "see"— he chuckled. —I perceive things you can't, as much as I miss details you *can* see. And I hadn't come across wounds like yours in… a long time.

—It's nothing…— she sighed, looking away.

—I *know* it's *not* nothing…— he denied, gesturing at his blindfold.

—Don't tell me…

—Yes— he nodded with a small smile. —I think I know why you're here. I'm glad.

—Is this really a better place?

—It is— he confirmed, right before turning as he felt Shadow Weaver was about to walk in. —My Lord, she's unable to move yet, but can speak. This needs to be applied to her back, but…

—I'll do it— she interrupted.

That was the voice.

—You- I-I remember that voice— she told the masked woman in dark red.

Yet she remained unfazed.

—Castaspella, right?— she asked, taking the mortar from the nurse before he left. —We have a lot to talk about…

—You're… the Dark Lord? So, Shadow Weaver?

—Yes… Who are you?

—No one— she denied, looking away.

—You're pretty beaten to be "no one".

—I think… people who *are* someone… get treated better— she uttered.

—That's fair. But I still need you to answer my questions— Shadow Weaver insisted.

—Sure…

—The arrows on your back tell me you were, likely, escaping when you arrived here. Is that correct?

—Yes.

—So, do you think you were followed?— Shadow Weaver asked, turning the young woman around to expose her back. —I was told you came through a portal.

—I don't think I could be followed… a-and they likely don't know where I am or they would be here already…

—Hmm, it's been almost two days, so yes, that's a correct assessment— she nodded, starting to apply the mix to the wounds on Castaspella's back, greatly surprised there was no reaction at all. —Doesn't it hurt?

—A lot…

—Then why…

—I've felt worse.

—I should have known…— Shadow Weaver sighed. —I read Zacharias' report, and I must now ask about the older wounds.

—What do you want to know?

—What are the cuts on your lower back?— she began.

—The corsets. Too tight, with metal reinforcement, which usually cut me.

—Corsets aren't supposed to hurt…

—Could have fooled me— Castaspella scoffed.

—The scars on your abdomen?— she went on.

—That- No-nothing…

—Zack says they look like surgery scars. But they are too many…

—Apparently I had too much skin— she let out, between gritted teeth.

It was evident she refused to elaborate, so the Dark Lord decided to drop the matter.

—Ah… I see— Shadow Weaver nodded, placing a hand on Castaspella's shoulder. —Stay like this on your side for a bit while the unguent is absorbed.

—Sure… What else do you want to know about?

—What are the marks on your arms?

—Bandages to-to help them fit into the dresses' sleeves.

—Why not get dresses tailored for your body?

—Don't ask *me*.

With a hum, she simply went on —The cuts and abrasion behind your ears?

—It's chemical… All the products to keep my hair "perfect".

—Huh… And the burns on your legs?

—*Sometimes* the wax was too hot, I guess— she sighed.

—What about the *other* times?

—Other times… I was crying too loud.

The Dark Lord closed her eyes as intense rage lit up inside her.

Not now.

Not yet.

—I will continue tomorrow— Shadow Weaver sighed, hiding her emotions. She then helped Castaspella rest back again, and told her —I'll bring you something to eat now, tell me when you feel like you can start moving your body.

It took Castaspella another day to finally get out of the bed, but in the meantime, she continued to tell Shadow Weaver the story of every single scar she asked about.

However, she never once revealed who inflicted those wounds.

—Why… are you interested in my scars? You're…

—The "cold-hearted" Dark Lord?— she interrupted, as they slowly walked through a garden, since she considered the young woman needed it. —I may be evil, but if there's one thing I don't tolerate, it's physical abuse…— Shadow Weaver explained, looking back at Castaspella, maskless.

—Can I ask… if that's related to your… split lip?

—Smart— she smirked. —Yes. In fact, I suffered much as a kid. But don't be fooled. I'm far from a good person, and I would be even worse if it weren't for… my only friend. He made sure I would not fall into the same violence my father inflicted on me— she explained. —Since then, I've made it my mission to fight such abusers… at any cost.

—Why did you conquer The Fright Zone?

—Because the regent was a man quite like my father. Aren't you listening?— Shadow Weaver mocked her. —I only ask people to do as I say, or they can leave. *But*, if they want to stay safe from such people…

—We can stay here— Castaspella understood.

—Do I take it you want to stay?

—O-of course! Wait… the physician- He was blind and… I think he hinted at… understanding what I've been through.

—It's not my story to tell, but I can confirm Zacharias does, in fact, understand. That's also why he was the best candidate to write the report on your wounds.

—Oh…

—Alright, you should rest now— Shadow Weaver decided, reaching a seat. —I believe you can leave the infirmary soon, so I must ask: are you serious about staying?

—Yes— Castaspella confirmed, determined.

—Then I'll prepare you a room.

—Wait…— she stopped her, reaching out with a hand. —Should… I return alone to the… infirmary, or…

—No, you wait here. I'll return for you or send someone to get you. Don't walk around alone just yet— she ordered.

—Alright— Castaspella accepted.

With that, Shadow Weaver finally left, and the young woman rested back, observing her surroundings, hearing the calm rustle of leaves, and the occasional cawing of a bird in the distance.

As the third day since the Princess' escape came to a close, Akane left Norwyn's cell, wiping her hands with a towel.

—Useless man, can't even break properly…— she scoffed. —I'll have to find some *other* way to find her…

—Your Majesty— a knight behind her called. —He insists Princess Esmeralda was killed. Is there no chance…

—*If* she was killed, it was one of *your* men, and that would mean *you* would have to pay— she clarified, immediately turning around with a tight smile. —So, for your own good, we will proceed under the belief that he's lying.

—Yes, Your Majesty. You're right, Your Majesty— the knight saluted. —Then… What am I supposed to tell the King?

—You'll tell him you're still searching for our daughter, and that if he has any further questions, he can come to me.

—And if he… figures out something's wrong?

—Then you must send him to me… to discuss things over dinner— she ominously smiled.

Chapter End Notes

Alright! That's all for today!

If you fear for Norwyn's integrity, you're absolutely right, I'm so sorry

About Casta's scars, most are based on things I've heard... or suffered :D but those are the least, I promise...

Anyways!! See you next week!!
Things get more interesting with each chapter, I promise!

Many thanks for reading!

Chapter 3

Chapter Summary

So recovery began…

Chapter Notes

I forgot to update, omgs…

Anyways <("^_^) here it is!

I hope you enjoy! :D

See the end of the chapter for more notes

About a week after the Princess' escape, Queen Akane wasn't any closer to getting information from Norwyn, nor finding Esmeralda on her own.

She could only resort to one thing, and she needed to think carefully about it.

If she *actually* got Micah to help her, to use some spell that could locate Esmeralda, then she'd need a *great* reason to justify her initial escape.

And, of course, she'd also need to be in complete control to make sure Micah wouldn't learn the whole truth. After all, she couldn't use on her son the same techniques she used on her husband…

Fine, she'll wait before getting his help.

It'd be her last resort…

Meanwhile, in The Fright Zone, Castaspella was finally recovered.

—Are you sure you don't need more rest?

—Of course not— she quickly replied, gesturing dismissively at the Dark Lord. —I need some fresh air, and these gardens are perfect for that…

—Is that your way of telling me you intend to join me every day from now on?

—Maybe?

—Huh…— she smirked. —Then the very least you could do is help me *tend* to these gardens…

—Su-sure!— the young woman replied, gladly surprised. —Though I've never…

—I'll teach you— Shadow Weaver offered. —But do *not* ruin anything, or you're not getting dinner.

Just like that, Castaspella's expression darkened, all her excitement gone, and the Dark Lord immediately knew she had messed up.

—Right.

—Forget that. It's- Don't- *Of course* you will get dinner— she quickly tried to fix it. —I- Just make sure to listen to me, and we won't have any problems.

—Yes, of course.

—Casta…— she called, reaching for her chin. —You know you won't be hurt here, right? I wouldn't starve you.

—No, it's- I get it. If I mess up, I deserve a punishment.

—But not *starvation*. I shouldn't have said that.

—Look, you're not… you're not a saint. It's alright.

—I insist— she remarked, tilting her face up to look at her. —I shouldn't have said that, you *do not* deserve starvation, and… you're *allowed* to make mistakes.

—But not to disobey you.

—If you disobey me for a good reason, I *may* let it pass…— Shadow Weaver smirked.

—Is that related to your famous moral code?

—Absolutely.

—Good— Castaspella smiled. —Alright, let's get to work. I'll try not to fuck up.

The day went by without incidents and, soon, night fell.

The young woman ended up covered in dirt, while Shadow Weaver remained prim and proper.

—You should take a bath…

—I should— she laughed. —But… I-I hadn't… noticed how nice it feels…

—To be filthy?

—To be *able* to be filthy and just be *told* to take a bath— she remarked.

—Ah… I see.

—I couldn't get a single drop of soil, dirt, sweat, or *anything* on me that stained my clothes or skin — Castaspella scoffed. —I once got hit by a boy running around, he got the side of my dress wet, and…

—Wait, you got punished for *that*!? How is that *your* fault!? Are you expected to *foresee* you will get hit by a running boy!?

—Yes— she replied, deadpan.

—You're tempting me to use a word I *never* use just to ask for the identity of who your abuser is…

—Oh, no, forget that— Castaspella insisted. —Really…

—I won't— Shadow Weaver pressed on. —Go, take a bath, and then join me at the dining room.

—Will you interrogate me again?

—Maybe…— she smirked. —You'll have to go to find out.

—Fine! Fine… Let's play that game— Castaspella accepted, giggling.

—At least you laugh now…

—I do, don't I?

On the other side of the Whispering Woods, in the kingdom of Bright Moon, Queen Angella and her husband were having tea together.

—Anything on your mind? You've been really silent…

—Sorry— Micah sighed. —I just haven't heard anything about my sister the whole week. My mother insists she's just sick, and that's why she's been absent from all official ceremonies, but then, why hasn't she written to me?

—Well, we don't usually hear from Glimmer that often, yet you don't worry as much. And you *told me* your sister is a rather cold person…

—Esmeralda is… I mean, yes, but… At least she could write something short to let me know she's fine— he insisted.

—Did you send her any letters?

—Twice.

—And it was always Queen Akane replying?

—Exactly!

—I don't know what to tell you, my Dear… If your sister doesn't want to reply herself, there may be a reason. Perhaps your mother is lying so you won't be upset, or perhaps Esmeralda *is* genuinely ill and can't reply.

—Then I should go to visit her— Micah considered.

—That's another possibility, yes— Angella chuckled. —Why haven't you yet if you were so worried?

—Be-because… Mother said- Well, I mean, Esmeralda hardly ever accepts visitors, and now Mother kept saying she needed to rest…

—I see…

—Angie, do you think she's mad at me?— he then asked, setting down his cup.

—Who?

—My sister.

—Why would she be mad at you?

—For leaving? For… I don't know… Not giving her enough attention? Maybe she acts cold because she wants people to make an effort to get closer…

—Has she always been so cold?

Micah had to think for a moment.

His first instinct was to say "yes", but something on the back of his mind thought otherwise.

—No…— he finally uttered. —I think… she was really warm and cheerful when we were little.

—Then what happened?

—Then… I don't know.

—Do you think joining the public world as a princess may have influenced her behaviour?— Angella considered.

—That's- Yeah, that could be it— he nodded. —Still, she could have- Why did she have to change *with me too*?

—Have you ever talked about this with her?

—No…

—My Love— Angella sighed. —How is your sister supposed to know you miss the way she was if you never tell her?

—You're right— he nodded, brushing his hands down his face. —I'll go visit her tomorrow…

That night, as they had dinner together, Shadow Weaver delayed her intended interrogation a bit, in favour for… seemingly irrelevant matters.

—Did you know you eat twice as fast as anyone I've ever known?

—You're…

—Swallow before talking— she interrupted the young woman.

—Sorry— Castaspella apologized after obeying. —I was- I'm sorry, it just caught me off guard.

—To answer what I think was your question, no, I'm not messing with you.

—Oh…

—You really eat much faster than anyone *should*.

—Re-really sorry about that… I've never noticed— the young woman blushed.

—How much time did you usually have to eat?

—Huh?

—How much- Wait— Shadow Weaver interrupted herself, thinking better about it. —Did you or did you *not* have time to eat?

Castaspella looked away, ashamed, and that told the Dark Lord enough.

But still, she waited for her to speak.

—I didn't *always* have. I tried to- I sometimes…sneaked into the kitchen.

—You had to *steal food*?

—Most of the time— she nodded. —When I *was* allowed to eat, I had to take so many precautions to avoid getting dirty that I hardly ate in the end.

—And how many times a day did you manage to eat?

—Twice on average. Trice if I was lucky, but most times just once— she replied, looking down at her empty plate. —I'm almost sure I will… earn some weight here— she chuckled.

—So I hope— Shadow Weaver smirked. —Zack did mention in his report that you were underweight.

Castaspella took a deep breath before letting out a long sigh.

—Why do you… take such good care of me?

—You mean, despite how little you reveal about yourself? When you haven't even given me your real name?

—Yeah…

—Well, while it's true that I know more about your scars than about you as a person… I think that's normal from someone who doesn't want to be found.

—I- Yes, but… I-I should… trust you more by now— Castaspella considered.

—You can't force trust— Shadow Weaver remarked, shaking her head. —You *shouldn't*. While I appreciate you wanting to trust me, I must advise you against it.

—Thank you… I want to, though… But I guess, not yet— she shyly smiled.

—Just let me warn you: I am *not* trustworthy… I can, and *will* use any information you give me…

—Against me?

—Maybe?

—What does it depend on?

—Whether it benefits me— she smirked.

—I call bullshit— Castaspella scoffed. —Yeah, you're self-serving, but I don't think you will "use information against me" if that means going against your morals…

—Hmm… Smart.

—Then yes, I think I can… trust you— she nodded. —In the morning.

As she daintily laughed, the young woman took a sip from her drink and hardly held back a yawn.

—Time to sleep?

—I don't want to, but I guess I should…

—I think you still need rest.

—I don't… want to leave yet— Castaspella admitted, looking away, face flushed.

—Is that so?— Shadow Weaver smirked.

—I-I mean…

—You're changing colours…

—Oh, shut up!— she cackled. —Listen, I just… I think I enjoy your company, alright? Nothing wrong with that, I hope…

—Nothing wrong— Shadow Weaver accepted. —On the contrary…

—Really?— Castaspella instinctively asked, hope shining in her eyes.

Suddenly, the Dark Lord felt… strange.

She was *not* expecting that reaction.

—I was going to joke about you not believing me, but now I'm curious: have you, genuinely, never had a friend or… just *anyone* who enjoys your company?

—Besides my brother…— she began, yet trailed off. —No, not really. Not anymore.

—You have a brother…

—I suppose— Castaspella confirmed, her expression bittersweet.

—Does he not know you… suffered so much? Did he not care? Or was he… part of the problem?

—I don't know. I suppose- Ma-maybe he didn't know. But maybe that's… wishful thinking…

—I see…— she nodded. After a moment of silence, she took a deep breath and proposed —Want to stay a bit more and have some tea?

—I-I'd like that, yes.

As midnight arrived, deep on Mystacor's underground corridors, a group of sorcerers had gathered.

Three hushed voices discussed in the darkness.

—So?— a female voice asked.

—I couldn't gather much, to be honest…

—*Any* information may be useful— a deeper voice insisted.

—Well… There's one cell in "the castle" that seems inhabited.

—You can't be saying…

—It's not sure, but no one else has disappeared, no official statement has been made…

—And what about the rumours of the-the *screams*?

—I-I didn't want to say this, but…

—Just spit it out.

—I think I found proof of torture, but I can't be sure it's *his*…

—What do you mean!?

—I have to show you…

—No— the deep voice interrupted. —We can't risk it.

—Then you'll have to trust me.

—And do what!?— the female voice scoffed. —Sit and do nothing?

—You can always throw everything out of the window and *try* to expose the Queen, but the knights will make sure it ends in nothing.

—We *can't* risk it! This will end in bloodshed— the deep voice insisted.

—Certainly.

—Then leave, don’t return, and from now on, work *alone* to find the Head Sorcerer.

With that, the three unsubs parted ways, made it out of the tunnels separately…

And once on the surface…

…all three got intercepted by knights.

Chapter End Notes

<("^_^) ehe
This chapter ended quite dark, I know
BUT THAT'S THE POINT

:D See you next week with a new chapter XD
Also, I'll have to update the tags soon because the BFS will appear! Woohh!!

But later, later…

Thanks for reading!!

Chapter 4

Chapter Summary

Until the sweet dream threatened to end…

Chapter Notes

Oh, finally! One of my favourite chapters!!!

Welcome back, everyone! Today I bring you Ch 4 XD
Featuring: a visual at the end >v<
I swear, I just love the end of this chapter so much, I *had* to add that visual

Anyways! No spoilers! Please enjoy :D

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Castaspella woke up suddenly from a nightmare.

It was… awful.

It felt so *real*.

She was back in "the castle" and there were knights all around her.

She felt alone, cold, and couldn't speak.

Then someone stepped in front of her, and it was none other than the Dark Lord, with an empty expression.

But it was a *nightmare*.

Just… a nightmare.

She *wasn't* in Mystacor, she was at the Fright Zone's fortress.

And she was taken care of, fed, *healed*…

It shouldn't surprise her to have these nightmares, but she couldn't understand why *now*, after a whole week!

Was she, perhaps, scared of Shadow Weaver ever treating her like Queen Akane?

The previous night she had mentioned wanting to trust her… was this why she hesitated?

—No, no!— she told herself. —She's not- She can't be… I-I *can* trust her.

Taking deep breaths, Castaspella got up from bed and went to take a quick bath.

Meanwhile, the Dark Lord herself hadn't slept all night.

She had this… *feeling*.

That kind of feeling that has *always* been right before.

What was it about this time?

Part of her was sure it was related to that young woman… but that only made it worse, as a matter of fact.

And if that wasn't enough, she was she sure she- No, no.

That couldn't be.

Absolutely forget it.

No.

Shadow Weaver got up from bed, did a thousand things to distract herself, but nothing worked.

So now, she just paced around the room, pensive, hands joined behind her back, glaring at the ground.

She felt so ridiculous.

Why would she- No! She wouldn't even *think* about it.

No, no.

As the day advanced, each focused on herself.

The women didn't know it, but they were avoiding the other… simultaneously.

On the contrary, for everyone else it was *blatantly obvious*, yet no one would dare point it out to the Dark Lord… Or mention it to Castaspella, for that matter, since they didn't know her enough.

The circus lasted all morning until, for lunch, the few servants Shadow Weaver had around decided to manipulate the situation a bit.

—Look who's here…

—Ah- Uh, sorry, I…

—Haven't seen you all day.

—I know— Castaspella sighed, hugging herself.

—Anything I should be aware of?

—N-no, no…

—Good— she smirked under the mask. —Then you'll have no problem sharing lunch with me since… we don't seem to have a choice…

—I- No- O-of course I don't have a problem— Castaspella stammered. —Wha-what do you mean we have no choice?

—Haven't you noticed?

—I'll play it safe and go with "no".

—I call bullshit…— Shadow Weaver scoffed. —Or maybe you have allowed yourself to be more naïve now that you can afford it…— she considered. —In any case, I won't pretend I haven't been avoiding you, and *don't you dare* deny you have too. They noticed, and we've been set up.

—Oh— the young woman sighed, blushing. —Bu-but…

—It's all innocent, don't worry.

—I-I- O-of course…

—That also means if you *really* don't want to have lunch with me, you don't have to— the Dark Lord clarified.

—No! I mean, *yes*! I- No, well, like…— she rushed to say, before taking a deep breath to try again. —I think I should… have lunch with you, yes. I need to… talk.

—Oh, even better— she replied, her tone mocking to hide the rush of shyness that threatened to reveal itself despite the mask.

—I-I'm serious. I want to… tell you the truth— she admitted, voice losing strength.

—Come on, let's sit— Shadow Weaver encouraged her, suddenly more gentle, but also more serious.

However, just as the women were about to step into the dining room, a short man Castaspella knew well now arrived running.

—My Lord!— he screamed. As he shook something in the air, he gasped for air, seemingly having run for a while. —I have… a message… official… from… ah…

—Calm down— she ordered, raising a hand. Just as he reached them, she straightened her back and commanded —Breathe and then tell me what this is.

—An official… declaration… from the neighbouring… kingdom…— he explained, between each deep breath. As she quickly skimmed it, he explained —They say… you kidnapped… their Princess… And if you don't… Ugh… if you don't return her, they… will declare war.

—No…

Castaspella took a step back, then another, losing her senses little by little, and feeling her world crumble.

The sweet dream had to end at some point, no?

She could almost hear the voice of her mother mocking her naïveté.

That was it, wasn't it…

She should have known.

The young woman spiraled for what felt like an eternity before the voice of the Dark Lord reached her.

—Casta…

—I was going to- I swear, I wanted to… tell you…— she let out, her voice a whisper as she felt breathless.

—Casta, calm down.

—I promise… I didn't want to cause you trouble— she insisted, not noticing she was now on her knees, and Shadow Weaver didn't hesitate to kneel in front of her to cup her face. —Sorry…

—Listen to me: calm down. Breathe. It's alright.

—I…

—You're Princess Esmeralda of Mystacor?— she asked, serious. As she nodded, the Dark Lord went on —Does that mean Queen Akane did… all of that to you?

—Yes…— Castaspella sobbed. —I don't want to be Princess anymore— she let out, almost choking.

—Then you aren't— Shadow Weaver assured her. —Do you hear me? You're Castaspella. There's no Princess Esmeralda anymore.

The young woman looked up at her with such hope in her eyes that the Dark Lord felt a swell of pride invade her and, without thinking, stood up, took the declaration, and wrote something at the end.

—Do I… return it to them?— the short man inquired, hesitant upon reading her answer.

—You better— she laughed. —Meanwhile, we'll have our lunch— she then told Castaspella, helping her up from the ground.

—What… Di-did you reply?— she sniffed, letting Shadow Weaver take her into the dining room.

—I did.

—Huh?

Taking off her mask, she smirked —They threatened us with war if I don't send you back. Guess war is nigh.

There was nothing but genuine amusement in her expression.

Castaspella could hardly believe it.

No way.

—Seriously!?

—Yes.

—I think I- Uh, thank you?— she quickly caught herself, before accidentally saying something *very stupid*.

—Save it— Shadow Weaver laughed. —Sit now, I'm starving…

—I- Yes, same here…

Just earlier, that same day, Micah showed up in Mystacor without a warning.

Queen Akane almost had a heart attack.

—My dear son…— she began, finally daring to face him. —I wasn't expecting you to come. Is everything alright?

—No, Mother, far from alright— he scoffed. —I want to see my sister— he demanded.

—I told you she…

—Yes, I know! That's why I came to visit! Let me talk to her…

—She can't receive you right now— she reminded him.

—Why!?

—Please, calm down, Micah…— she requested, refusing to reply. —You're getting hysteric.

—I am not hysteric! I'm worried! Did I do something!? Does she hate me!?— he insisted, on the verge of tears.

—Alright, my Dear, come with me…— she sighed, wanting to take him somewhere more private and buying some time to think.

What could she say!?

How could she convince him not to get involved!?

Or maybe…

Maybe it was time to make use of this last resort.

—Where are you taking me?— Micah then asked, after a few minutes following his mother through tight corridors.

—I must tell you something— she somberly began. —Do you remember Head Sorcerer Norwyn?

—Of course…

—He's a traitor— she sentenced, turning to face him as they reached a secluded garden. —He sent your poor sister somewhere… and refuses to tell us where.

—What- No, wait, what do you…

—A week ago, he was found opening a portal— the Queen carefully explained. —However, before the knights could stop him, he pushed Esmeralda through it— she lied. —We've been interrogating him, but he won't talk…

—Mother, why didn't you tell me!? I-it's impossible!

—I knew you wouldn't believe me. That's why I didn't tell you— she replied, feigning sorrow.

—You should have! I can find her!— he insisted. —I just need a basin and some lunar crystals powder.

—My Son, you have your own kingdom to take care of. This isn't something you should be…

—Forget it, Mother. She's my sister— Micah interrupted her, oblivious to her pretense.

—Very well. Then I'll let you find her, but afterwards, let *us* handle her recovery.

—Of course— he smiled.

—Well then, you can use the basin of the Lunarium— she offered.

With a nod, he immediately headed for it, and Akane watched him rush away.

After a moment, she couldn't help the small twitch of her lips.

That was easier than imagined.

And it only got *better* as her son later found her with the results of the Pulse spell: Esmeralda was in The Fright Zone.

From then on, the Queen only had to let Micah's rage do everything.

His indignation blinded him, he wanted the Dark Lord to pay, and was the first one to propose sending a formal declaration to the Fright Zone, accusing Shadow Weaver of kidnapping Princess Esmeralda and demanding her immediate return.

However, their messenger returned alone with the declaration, and it was the Prince who run to meet him.

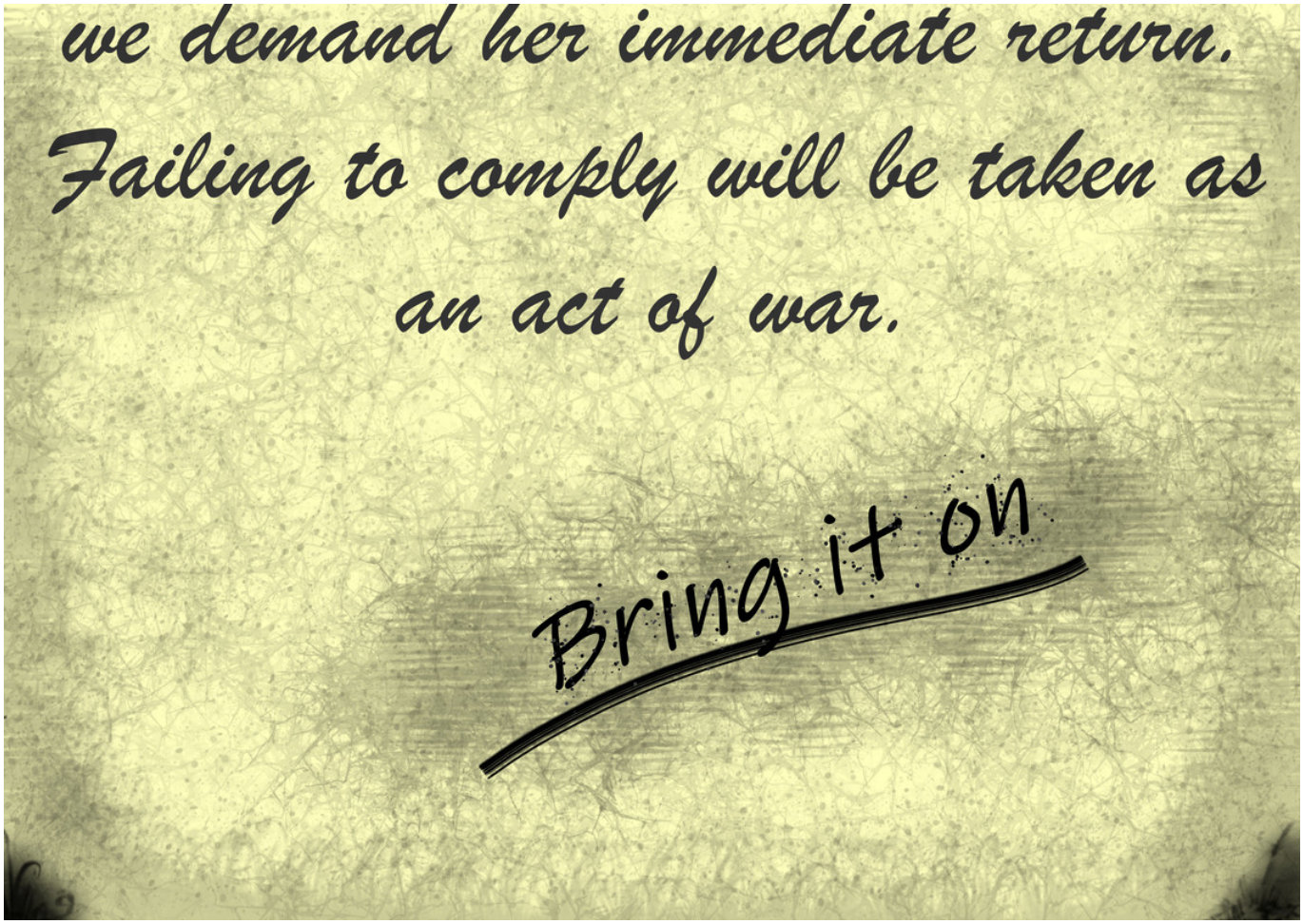
—What!?— Micah exclaimed.

—What is it?— his mother asked, rushing behind him but not wanting to trip on her heels.

—The Dark Lord replied at the bottom.

—And what does it say?— Akane inquired, expectant.

—“Bring it on”.



Chapter End Notes

XD ehe

I don't know, I just find it hilarious
Ofc SW would reply like that XD

Also, kudos if you noticed the two references in the chapter XD They were 100% on purpose lol

Alright, enough rambling.
See you next week!!! (we're getting closer to the chapter where the BFS appear and more lore will be revealed :D)

Thanks for reading!!

Chapter 5

Chapter Summary

The nightmare unfolds…

Chapter Notes

Oh wow! Look, we're back!! :D
This is an interesting chapter
Kinda short, but like, it packs a bit of a punch :3

Anyways, you'll soon see what I'm talking about XD

Please enjoy!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The Queen was staring at the wall.

Her thoughts were just a constant stream of questions.

What…

How!?

And why!?

She couldn't make it *make sense*.

The King had left her alone in their room after trying and failing to communicate with her, but even after hours, she was still in the same place he left her.

—Dad… do you…

—I'm sorry, Micah. I don't know— he interrupted, anticipating his question.

—What do we do?

—We… wait?

—More!?

—Listen, Son. I don't have her ability to fix things— the King explained, defeated. —I can only hope she will come to her senses eventually. She must be… processing it.

Oh, she was… but not as they thought.

—But- I can't do *nothing* in the meantime.

—I know, Micah. So we will let her have some more time, and start planning our next move— he replied. —After all, I suppose we're at war now.

—I can't believe this— he scoffed. —And she said Norwyn helped the Dark Lord?

—So it would seem.

—Then I'll talk to him— Micah decided.

—I would tell you to do that, but… your mother gave the knights strict orders not to let anyone see him.

—Why!?

—I don't know…

—Ugh!

—Son, listen: I think you should return home with your wife, and if you want, you can come back here when we have our plan. We can't make a move until then.

—What if the Dark Lord attacks first?

—I don't think that will happen, but we can always hold the line as long as needed— the King assured him.

—Alright— Micah sighed. —Thank you, Dad. I'll return and let Angella know what happened.

—Send her my regards— his father replied, seeing him off.

As the Queen heard their footsteps fade, her eye started twitching.

Norwyn.

Why had he… *sent her there*!?

And why did he insist she was *dead*!?

Unless he genuinely didn't know?

Well, that gave her an idea, then…

Back in the Fright Zone, Castaspella finished her meal with Shadow Weaver.

—Feeling any better?

—Not really… I-I know why, and I appreciate it, but… I can't believe you chose war over handing me in.

—War is more fun than letting you back with your abusers— the woman smirked.

—What!?— Castaspella coughed, almost choking. —War isn't fun!

—Have you ever had a war? Wait, don't answer that— Shadow Weaver uttered, pensive. —Mystacor hasn't seen war in too long, of course you haven't…

—Well, but I don't need to— she scoffed. —War brings death and destruction! Of course it isn't…

—Yes, yes, and I'm not saying the opposite, but you obviously don't understand the thrill of strategically planning the downfall of your enemy…— the Dark Lord argued.

—That sounds insane— Castaspella muttered. —Why am I not appalled?

—Aren't you?

Shadow Weaver raised a brow while giving her a look that made the young woman blush.

—Shut up.

—You're…

—Shut *up*!— she insisted, holding back a smirk. —I'm serious!— she added, while her expression contradicted her.

Laughing freely, the Dark Lord stood up from her chair and offered her hand to Castaspella, saying —Come with me, now. I want to take a walk with you.

—Su-sure…

They were silent at first.

The young woman was still red, but Shadow Weaver no longer cared about that.

She also didn't let go of her hand.

—I need to know something…— she began, as they walked at a slow pace.

—Yes?

—Why did you come here? And how?

—Oh, I never told you, did I?

—Not a word. And this isn't somewhere most people would choose, plus, you couldn't have opened the portal yourself— she sighed. —So, why here?

—I was- I mean, the man who sent me here said other regents would- Well, that they would do the opposite of you, precisely. Anyone else would send me back, but you… chose war. He was right— Castaspella spoke, more like thinking aloud.

—Who?

—The Head Sorcerer— she replied, immediately feeling Shadow Weaver's hand squeeze hers.

—Norwyn?

—Yes.

—That night it didn't snow…— she then uttered, frozen in place all of a sudden. —What happened to him?

—I-I'm not sure— Castaspella admitted. —My mother's knights found us and he told me to cross the portal, and… after the arrows hit me, I don't remember much.

—What would they do if they caught him?

—I hope he escaped…

—What would they *do*!?— Shadow Weaver insisted, grabbing her by the shoulders. —Tell me.

—Torture— Castaspella sentenced, serious. —And nothing light, I'm sure.

—I must- Come with me— she ordered, suddenly rushing back to her room.

—What will you do!?— the young woman asked, running after her.

—How much magic do you know?

—In theory? All known spells— she replied, a bit cocky. As they arrived at the Dark Lord's chambers, she lowered the pace and admitted —Practically, only defense stuff.

—Alright, so I don't have to explain the Pulse spell to you.

—Oh- That's smart— Castaspella realized.

Immediately, the women surrounded a basin installed at the back of the room and Shadow Weaver cast the pertinent spell, summoning images of the former Head Sorcerer.

—What… am I seeing?

—The prison. The-the dungeons.

—But that… can't be him— the Dark Lord denied.

—It doesn't look like him, but- No, wait. Do you see that!? Those were the robes he was using!— Castaspella assured her, pointing at a detail on the mirage.

—Then why…— she began, yet trailed off as she found the answer to her own question. —His… horns.

—Oh… no— the young woman uttered, her eyes filling with tears. —No, no… It's my fault…

—No, it is not. You did *not* excise his horns!— Shadow Weaver spat, gripping the sides of the basin. —You- It is *not* your fault— she insisted, more like trying to convince herself. —But I will admit: I am *glad* we're going to war, because I *will* avenge that old ram… at any cost.

Back in Mystacor, while her husband gathered the generals to come up with a battle plan, Queen Akane visited Norwyn.

The man hadn't spoken a word since she took his horns, but she was convinced this time he would.

—Aren't you tired of this?— she first said, as soon as she reached the bars of the cell. —Don't you want me to end your misery?— she insisted. Of course, there was no reply. —Why do you cling onto dear life? You insisted Esmeralda was dead… so I wonder, were you hoping she'd be alive?— she then asked, feigning innocence. —In any case, it doesn't matter anymore. I don't need your answers: My dear son already found her… alive, and in the Fright Zone.

Norwyn's eyes suddenly opened.

They were reddened, but not empty as they had been until then.

Esmeralda was alive and had reached Shadow Weaver.

—She did it— he uttered.

—Did you say something?— Akane asked, surprised. —Hopefully you aren't too happy about this — she then said, smirking. —After all, we're going to war over my daughter, and I can assure you, there will be nothing left of the Fright Zone when we're done.

Norwyn let out a sudden cackle.

Loud, maniacal…

Why was he *laughing*!?

The Queen felt her blood boil and immediately shook the bars of the cell.

—You're done for!— he continued to laugh.

—What are you talking about!?

—You are *doomed*— he snickered, never looking back at her. —How ironic…

—Speak clearly! I demand an explanation!

—You will find out on your own— he replied, glaring at her with renewed fire in his eyes. — You… stand no chance.

—Why!? What do you mean!?

—You messed with the Dark Lord. And you are asking me what I mean!?— he asked back. —You were supposed to be smart, not just *wicked*.

—You!— Akane growled, clenching her jaw. —Explain yourself or I'll…

—You will *what*!? You took everything from me already— he laughed at her. —All that's left is my life, and if you take it too, then I can be *sure* I'll be avenged— he smirked.

—What interest would the Dark Lord have in you!?

—You wouldn't understand— he scoffed. —You're *nothing* compared to her… Wicked, yes, but you stand on no ground, you have no real power. It's just a question of time before everyone turns against you.

—Anyone who dares *think* about turning against me will be dealt with— she retorted. —Like your sorcerer friends…— she then added, malicious.

—Huh?

—I caught three of your followers. Didn't you hear them scream?

—What did you do to them?

—Nothing close to what I did to you— Akane smirked. —They were granted some mercy, you could say.

—The weight of their deaths will fall on you one day, and regardless of whether I'm alive or dead, I will be *relieved* when it happens— he promised.

—Keep dreaming, old man…

Meanwhile, on the upper floors, the King was having a headache.

—Your Majesty…— the closest knight called, helping him sit down. —Let us handle this, you can rest.

—No, no. I need to-to recover… my daughter— he insisted, clutching his head. —I… need to protect her.

—Of course, your Majesty, but you also need to take a break.

—I can't! Why-why am I… so dizzy!?— he gasped, starting to panic.

He wasn't aware, but the more he thought about his daughter, the worse it got.

And right now, Esmeralda was the only thing on his mind.

But how could he ever know?

In any case, he had no choice in the matter as, soon enough, he passed out from the pain.

It was just a second for him. One moment he was in the war-room, the next, he was in bed, slowly starting to see the ceiling.

A hand held his… it was Micah.

—Father?— he asked, realizing he regained consciousness.

—What… happened to me?

—You fainted a few hours ago— he replied, grabbing a glass of water to offer him. —Mother asked me to come as soon as I could… I've been here for half an hour, but you've been out all afternoon— he explained.

—I don't know what happened.

—The knights say you had a major headache.

—I was- I was planing… I was thinking about your sister… I can't- Ugh!— he gasped, suddenly breathless. —Why can't I… think about her… without…

—Hold on, Dad, wait— Micah uttered, immediately casting the first healing spell he could think about. —I think this will help— he hoped, seeing his father's expression relax. —What were you thinking about?

—I just… wondered why she would… escape.

—She escaped? I thought Norwyn had…

—Norwyn?

—The Head Sorcerer?

—Yes, he… what happened to him?— he asked, feeling the headache return but seemingly held back by Micah's spell.

—He sent Esmeralda to the Fright Zone! He-he's… a traitor.

—I remember… seeing him… in-in a cell… Ugh— he spoke, soon interrupted by the pain. —Micah, you need to find him…

—Why him?

—Esmeralda… escaped. She- Agh!

—Dad!

The Prince stood up suddenly, his heart racing upon seeing his father's eyes bleed.

—What's wrong!?— a knight suddenly asked, just arriving at the chamber.

—I need a healer!— Micah pleaded. —Quick!

—Right away!

—Dad, Dad! Please, hold on…

Chapter End Notes

There you have it <("^_^) poor guy…

BUT! We're almost half-way through! I'm so excited!! >v<

However, I have had a hard time writing the last chapter, so I can't rush to post the rest even if I want to <("^_^)

Also, today I had my first Japanese Language Exam!! :D I'm so happy!!
I definitely feel better than last week, that's for sure…

Oh well, anyways…
Thank you so much for reading!! :D See you next week!! (#^_^#)

Chapter 6

Chapter Summary

Little by little…

Chapter Notes

Welcome back!!
I hope you're ready for more :D

Today we have, uh… and interesting chapter XD

But I won't bore u any longer, please enjoy!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The news of the King's sudden "illness", or rather "attack" as per the official statement, soon reached every kingdom.

But the reason…

—They are accusing me of *what now*!?

—I am sorry, My Lord— the short man apologized.

—What do you- *You* did nothing worth being sorry for…— Shadow Weaver scoffed. —I'm surprised, however, that such strange phenomenon occurred. Does Castaspella know?

—Yes…— he nodded. —She's been crying at the library ever since.

—Alright— the Dark Lord sighed. —This was… last night, right?

—Exactly, but the kingdoms were notified this morning and we caught a messenger just a few minutes ago.

—Then how did Casta find out?

—She- Well, *she* caught the messenger— he stammered.

—Excuse me!?

—She was practicing random spells… with some of us… It-it was a game.

—Incredible.

—Excuse me, My Lord.

—Nothing to apologize for— she insisted. —Tell the cooks to prepare some tea and send it to the library— she then ordered. —She will need it.

A few minutes later, Shadow Weaver found the young woman curled up on a sofa.

She wasn't sobbing, but it was clear she had been crying.

About ten books laid around her, half of them open.

—Why…— she sniffed, clutching her head.

—Casta?

—Ah— she gasped, looking up. —I-I'll clean up.

—What were you looking for?

—What?

—In these books?

—I- No-nothing.

—Casta…

—Did you hear the news?

—Yes.

—My- I have a suspicion… about what happened to my father.

—Explain.

—He was… always good to me. But he seemed oblivious to *everything*. And I always thought he was… I don't know, pretending he didn't notice anything— she began, still curled up as the Dark Lord sat next to her. —But… one night I found out… that-that my mother was giving him something.

—Something?

—With his dinner. Whenever he questioned her about anything, she'd… have a special dinner with him and, next time you'd see him, he wouldn't have any idea what you were talking about if you mentioned his doubts.

—She drugged him!?

—I think.

—So you were trying to find out with what?

—I'm trying to find any kind of clue about what that was, or why he bled through his eyes now…

—I don't know many things that can do that. A few plants mixed on his food, maybe a distillate in his drink instead…

—Which ones?

With a sigh, the Tyrant leant down, picked a book, and passed some pages.

—These and… these— Shadow Weaver indicated her, showing the plants in the book. —However, the bleeding should have happened much sooner— she pointed out.

—What if something triggered it?

—Something like what?

—If it's something that alters his memory, as I think, and he was discussing a battle plan, as the messengers have been saying… maybe he was- ma-maybe he was thinking about me…

—And his real memories, forced back by the drug, tried to resurface but hurt him instead— Shadow Weaver considered.

—Exactly. What could cause that?

—That's likely a complex potion. I'm almost impressed- Or I'd be, if it weren't such a nasty move — she scoffed.

—You are allowed to be impressed by her, you know? You're supposed to be evil, or whatever…

—I wouldn't use it on my own husband— she smirked. —So to speak— she then added, laughing.

—Yes, I know, your moral code…

—Precisely. Besides, she's a coward. She's wicked but pretends to be innocent— Shadow Weaver pointed out. —*Pathetic*.

Castaspella giggled, covering her mouth, but only for a second before feeling bad for it and blushing deeply.

—Sorry, sorry… That was- I-I didn't mean to laugh.

—You did, and I'm *glad*— she remarked. —Ah, just in time— she then sighed, noticing the servant approaching them with a tray. —Tea?

—Oh, thank you very much— she accepted. —I feel kind of cold…

—It's just a sensation, I'm sure— the Dark Lord commented. —You're worried about your father, with all due reason, and have been crying enough to dehydrate yourself— she then said, slightly mocking.

—Don't be mean…

—I'm offering you tea.

—You're being *mean* while doing it!— Castaspella laughed. —But… thank you.

—Of course…

—Can…— she then hesitantly began, after the first sip. —Can you keep me company for a while?

—Gladly— she accepted. —Have you had breakfast?

—Not really… I can't eat.

—You need to, but… I suppose we can wait until lunch— she accepted.

—Thank you…— Castaspella sighed. After a moment of silently drinking their teas, she asked — Do you think… I-if I managed to craft a cure- or just something that could, I don't know, purge the drug from his system, do you think it'd be possible to send it to my father?

—I can't promise you it'd be possible, however, I'd start by finding the right mix, and *if you do*, then we can figure out the logistics of getting it delivered without Queen Akane knowing.

—Thank you— she smiled, giggling. —Am I thanking you too much?

—Not more than when I had those new clothes tailored for you— she laughed.

—Oh- Did I really…

—You did— she nodded, letting out a smirk. —Ask the tailor if you don't believe me.

—I trust you— she chuckled. —But I… really should do something to repay you properly— Castaspella sighed. —I mean, you've given me so much and now there's… the whole war thing…

—You needn't repay anything. With time, you will eventually do as much, and won't notice it.

—Are you sure?

—Don't feel indebted, Casta— Shadow Weaver insisted. —I mean it.

—Alright— she smiled. —I appreciate it.

With that, they once again drank their tea in silence, enjoying their company and the warmth of their mugs.

Little by little, Castaspella looked more relaxed, and eventually, she rested back on the couch and put her legs down.

Shadow Weaver didn't notice herself staring until the young woman looked back.

—Glad to see you better.

She only smiled in silence and nodded cordially.

Meanwhile, back in Bright Moon, Micah arrived home with a vial of something.

—Welcome back— his wife greeted him. —How is your father?

—Angie, I need to get this analyzed— he told her, instead of replying.

—What is it?

—Mother says this was… found by the knights. That the Dark Lord must have had it sneaked into the kingdom…

—This… poisoned your father?

—That's the theory— he nodded, albeit hesitant.

—You aren't convinced.

—Nothing makes sense— he muttered. —I don't… trust anything.

—Why are you whispering?— she asked, her tone lower too.

—So-sorry. I must be paranoid— he sighed. —Because, if Mother is right, then the Dark Lord has people everywhere. But if not… then… I can't trust my own mother.

—Oh, my Love…

As she hugged him tight, covering him with her wings, she discreetly took the vial.

—So…

—I don't think it needs analysis. You mother must be right, so you should focus on finding out *how* it got to "the castle"— she loudly replied. —Just keep it saved in case we need it as proof in the future, alright?— she then told him, giving him a look that confused him for a second before he finally got it.

—Good idea. Thank you, Angie.

With that, the Queen of Bright Moon asked him to get ready for lunch and announced she'd find him later in the dining room.

Then, with carefully planned moves, she left the vial in the capable hands of her trusted physicians, with orders to analyze it.

After all, Angella had always had her reasons to want Glimmer far from them.

From the kingdom politics, from the throne…

And specially from her grandmother.

The following day, early in the morning, Castaspella was getting changed before going for breakfast.

Once again, disbelief invaded her.

This was her room, her clothes, her mirror in which she was staring at herself…

But this wasn't "Princess Esmeralda". Just "Castaspella"…

She felt so comfortable and safe.

So much so, she could hardly believe it had been only ten days.

Yet that same thought filled her with dread as she remembered Norwyn.

She couldn't begin to imagine what he had suffered…

Before she realized, she was hyperventilating, slowly kneeling until her hands were on the ground. She had to push herself up and, while gasping for air, hugged herself, mentally repeating she had to calm down.

After what felt like an eternity, she did manage to normalize her breathing, brushed away the tears she didn't notice she had shed, and stood up.

Heading for the door, she took deep breaths and told herself everything was fine.

But she knew it wasn't…

—Who am I kidding?— she sighed, opening the door only to be surprised by Shadow Weaver seemingly about to knock. —Shit- You scared me!

—I'll take that as a compliment— she first joked, before noticing her reddened eyes. —Were you crying?

—No-no… Well, yes, but it's nothing.

—Uhu, sure…— the old woman uttered, rolling her eyes. —Alright, I'll go straight to the point: I arranged things so you can work with the apothecary, the physicist, and the alchemist on a cure for your father.

—You have a *lab* here!?

—Obviously— Shadow Weaver rolled her eyes again. Then, smirking smugly, she asked —Impressed?

—I shouldn't be— Castaspella chuckled. —Thank you— she then smiled. —Would you- Have you had breakfast already?

—No.

She was, actually, waiting for her.

But she wouldn't say that…

—Would you accompany me, then?

—Gladly.

Castaspella began experimenting right that morning after eating.

The three experts helping her were actually rather impressed by her diligence.

But they also got a bit scared of her frustration.

—It's alright— Zacharias tried to tell her, after the fifth failure. —We don't know what we're working with. This will take time.

—He may not have time! I-I can't be so useless!

—You're *not useless*— the alchemist immediately replied. —You've actually figured out more than any of us three could— she pointed out. —Cures are usually more difficult to craft than poison, and that's definitely harder if we *don't* have a sample of the drug we're trying to counter.

—But I should be *able* to- Ugh! So many years seeing that thing… I *should* be able to do this!

—Not true at all— the apothecary scoffed. —It's like trying to identify a powder with your eyes alone!

Grunting, Castaspella paced back and forth, seemingly on the verge of hyperventilating.

—Castaspella, maybe you need to take a break— Zacharias suggested. —And I'd say, if you don't do so on your own, the Dark Lord will make sure you do.

—It's lunchtime anyways, this is a good moment to rest…— the alchemist commented.

—No! What if…

—Listen to me— the apothecary interrupted, making her stop pacing. —If the information we have is correct, then your father still has time— they assured her. —Go have lunch, give this more thought, and then return to experiment a bit more.

—You won't succeed immediately— the alchemist remarked. —And it's alright. Do you understand that?

—I… don't think I do— she admitted, looking down.

—Alright— Zacharias sighed. —Please, go have lunch. We've recorded everything and we'll analyze all the information we have. Meet us later, and we can keep researching. Is that okay?

—I… guess— Castaspella nodded.

—Am I interrupting?

The Dark Lord arrived just in time, pretending to knock on the door that wasn't even closed.

The young woman looked up immediately, face reddened, then glanced away, ashamed.

—My Lord— the three experts greeted her, bowing down.

—I'll take it you made little progress?

—We have gathered information and will proceed to analyze it. We were just telling Castaspella she can have lunch in the meantime.

—Perfect, Zack. Then I arrived just in time— she smirked. —Come on, Casta. You heard him.

—But I…

—You need to feed your brain if you want it to work— Shadow Weaver mocked her. —Come on.

—No— she said, suddenly serious.

The three experts exchanged concerned glances and took a step back.

—Casta…— she sighed. —Why do you refuse?

—I need to find the cure… I *must*— she insisted.

Taking a deep breath, the Dark Lord approached her, placed a hand on her shoulder, and severely stated —And you will. But you can't starve until you do.

—And what do you plan to do about it!?— Castaspella defied her, tears threatening to fall. —You can't even imagine all the punishments I've suffered! Nothing you can come up with will be worse than what I've already been through! You can't force me to stop, and I won't stop! I must…— she cried, now in full earnest, her voice breaking, until she got cut by Shadow Weaver.

Eyes closed, the old woman had pulled her into a hug.

Tight, warm, and seemingly far from ending.

—You… must take care of yourself first— she declared.

Eyes wide open in shock, the young woman felt frozen in place.

Why was she… hugging her?

And why did it feel so *nice*?

Little by little, Castaspella closed her eyes too and hugged her back, shyly at first, then tighter, until she let herself cry against Shadow Weaver's shoulder.

—I'm sorry…

—I know.

Chapter End Notes

(>v<) ehe

I know, poor Casta… <("^_^)

ANYWAYS! Next week, get ready! Because, at last, comes *the* chapter XD
You get more lore, some explanations, and bit of a rest from just seeing the schemes of Akane, or the struggles of Casta (/v\)

So, thank you so so much for reading and I'll see you next week!! :D

Chapter 7

Chapter Summary

It breaches containment…

Chapter Notes

Hi, welcome back!
I am once again posting a bit later than usual, this time because it seems my mom's dog is sick or was poisoned, and so it's been a bit hectic lately.

In any case, fortunately, this was ready to post since October, but I didn't have time to revise it last night, so I just did, and… it's incredible. I was super excited about this chapter, but now I'm just so tired and anxious…

But never mind, please, do enjoy the chapter, the new infos, and the increasing drama :D

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Noon was always the loudest time in Salineas Alliance School.

But in the past few days, it had been even worse.

Since the news of the incoming war between Mystacor and the Fright Zone, the alumni had divided, taking sides as if it were some sports' match.

So it was no surprise that the King of Mystacor being mysteriously attacked caused an uproar.

It was starting to get on Glimmer's nerves. And understandably so…

The young teen couldn't walk two steps without fellow students from either side wanting information from her.

And not like she had any more than them!

Yet they didn't understand, and they were far from respectful.

—Just tell us and we'll leave…

—Was your aunt kidnapped?

—Was the King poisoned?

—What do you know about your grandfather?

—Have you never seen your aunt!?

—Shut up!— Glimmer finally yelled, throwing her books to the ground.

How she wished she could teleport now.

—Alright, everyone *scram*!— an annoyed female voice ordered.

—You alright?— a boy then asked, picking up her books while the bothering students ran away.

—Thanks, guys— Glimmer sighed. —Won't you get in trouble if you do that, Catra?

—Nah…— she dismissed her. —I'm supposed to keep order in the halls, don't I?— she smirked. —Better stick with us, Sparkles. They are seriously insane…

—Here, Glim.

—Thanks, Bow— she accepted, taking back her books. —I'm just… still trying to process all that's happening at the other side of the sea…

—Yeah, it sounds like a lot— Catra nodded. —But why would *you* know anything? You're also here, getting the same news as the rest of us.

—And I haven't sent or received a single letter— she scoffed. —Can we get lunch?

—Yeah, we were actually coming to get your for lunch— Bow smiled. —Adora's waiting.

—Oh! Then let's go, yeah— Glimmer smiled.

Soon, they had found their friend and were having lunch together.

—So… I didn't want… to say anything— Adora began, speaking with her mouth full. —But… like, I don't… believe it.

—Adora— Catra grumbled, rolling her eyes. —We're not taking sides, and we're not…

—I know, I know!— she interrupted, after swallowing. —I-I didn't mean to gossip, I meant that, like, I don't think there's a reason for war! We know the Dark Lord wouldn't kidnap someone…

—Without a good reason, no— Catra smirked.

—She *wouldn't* kidnap anyone— Adora insisted. —If your aunt is there, she must have gone on her own— she told Glimmer. —So I'm sure she's fine! You don't have to worry!— she assured her. —A-and your grandfather- Well, that's even *more* unbelievable— she then scoffed. —She doesn't attack like that!

—Adora!— Catra insisted. —Does it matter? Even if that old hag wasn't the one to poison him, the fact remains that the King *was* attacked.

—She's right— Glimmer sighed. —I don't care who did it. I'm *worried* because it could be my dad next…

—Don’t think like that— Bow told her, placing a hand on her shoulder. —King Micah is a powerful sorcerer…

—But…— she tried to argue, yet got interrupted by her friend cupping her face.

—He will be fine— he insisted.

—I should be there with them…— she uttered, looking down.

—Nah, no way— Catra immediately replied. —I wouldn’t be surprised if they purposely sent you here to keep you safe.

—You think my parents expected this to happen?— Glimmer asked, looking back at her and raising a brow.

—Doesn’t it sound strange to you?— Adora asked back. —We’ve discussed it a few times and… it’s kinda weird that you’ve hardly seen your parents since your twelfth birthday, which is when princesses start preparing for the public world and whatnot… You also don’t know your aunt, or your grandparents…

—Well, yes- What’s your point?

—It doesn’t make sense, Sparkles— Catra scoffed. —It’s like they *wanted you away*. On purpose!

—They couldn’t have known my aunt would be kidnapped… I-I don’t even know why they want to…

—Nah, Shadow Weaver has no reason to kidnap anyone— she interrupted. —She literally took over the Fright Zone to *end* a war, alright? She wants to rule the few people who chose to stay and be left in peace— Catra explained. —It makes absolutely no sense for her to do any of the things Mystacor is accusing her of.

—Which doesn’t mean we’re taking sides!— Adora quickly clarified. —But… well, you know we come from there. So we kinda want to understand…

—I see what you mean, though— Bow nodded.

—I think I do too— Glimmer sighed. —I never thought about it, but it’s true that I don’t know Mystacor, or my family there— she admitted, looking away. —I guess I just didn’t want to consider it was… true.

—That what was true?— Catra asked, curious.

—I have this memory… I’ve been telling myself it was a dream, but I have no reasons to have dreamt something so specific— she began, leaning on the table, arms crossed. —The night before I got sent here, I… think, my mother came to check if I was asleep. I was just dozing off, so I kinda saw her, and heard her…

—What did she say?

—That I’d be safe now— she replied, serious. —Away from “her” and “her schemes”— she went on. —And then she lamented not being able to do more…

—What do you think it means?

—Well, now I think- I mean, back then it meant nothing. Then I heard rumours about Mystacor's royal family being just a façade. That the illusion of perfect peace was… hiding something dark.

—Wait, *those* rumours about… the Queen?

—Yeah— Glimmer nodded. —I think that may be what Mom meant.

—But then…— Adora reflected. —Oh, that makes more sense!

—Huh?— Catra inquired.

—What if her aunt actually *escaped*!? You know, if there's *anyone* who would protect her, that's Shadow Weaver!

—What are you talking about?— Bow asked, confused now.

—Alright: let us tell you a bit of lore you don't know about the Dark Lord— Catra decided to explain. —Namely, her strict moral code.

—It's a real thing?

—Very— Adora nodded. —Everyone who lived in the Fright Zone back then knows this, but we don't talk about it much…

—It's a way of keeping Shadow Weaver's motivations as secret as possible— Catra smirked.

—For context: she arrived at the kingdom one day as a complete no one. She made her way into the higher ranks, and eventually gained power. She kept herself on the sidelines, didn't call attention to herself, and followed orders from Hordak, who was the kingdom's ruler at the time.

—But *he* followed orders from someone else, someone called Horde Prime, who was… well, awful — Catra took over. —Eventually, and this is the part where history was purposely changed, Shadow Weaver convinced Hordak that Prime was just a wicked man with no real power, and they both raised the Fright Zone against him.

—What!?

—But Hordak didn't want to rule— Adora went on. —So, after Prime was gone, Hordak left her the Fright Zone, pretended everything had been her doing alone, and left the kingdom. *But*, the emphasis was always on how she did *not* tolerate abusive behaviour.

—Like, yeah, she's not the nicest person around, but if she ever heard of anyone torturing their underlings, parents harming their kids, or anything the like, you could be *sure* she'd intervene— Catra explained.

—Why would she…

—That's the interesting part, Sparkles. She has a friend, a man from Mystacor, who apparently convinced her it was better to take her rage out on abusers than be one herself.

—Shadow Weaver is rumoured to have suffered when she was a kid. And she would have been the same as an adult if it weren't for that friend— Adora further explained. —And *he* happens to be the Head Sorcerer of Mystacor.

—What!?— Glimmer and Bow exclaimed in unison.

—Yup.

—Wait, wait… so… Ok, no, that… makes sense— she nodded, eyes wide open as realization hit. —If the rumours about Queen Akane are true, then my aunt suffered her a lot. She could have heard of this from him, and escaped to the Fright Zone! A-and now her parents, my grandparents, made all those accusations to… go to war?

—Which is not smart at all— Catra uttered. —Though, if the King was supposedly attacked, either that's a lie or… he's not- Wait.

—What?

—Oh, shit!— she gasped, connecting the dots. —What if *the Queen* did that!?

—Poison her own husband!?

—Well, if you recall correctly, your mother was concerned about *her*, not about *them*.

—Oh…— Glimmer sighed. —I-I think I need to talk to Mom.

—Glim…— Bow stopped her, before she could stand from the table. —I don't think you should get involved.

She looked down, expression darkening, and nodded.

—I know… But if this is all true…

—I think Queen Angella is aware, if all this speculation holds any water, and she can handle it. Your dad will learn about it when your mom thinks he should, and… your grandfather may be in more danger if Queen Akane learns there are *any* suspicions set on her— he explained. —As for your aunt… As long as she's with the Dark Lord, she's as safe as can be.

—Should we do anything about the Head Sorcerer?— Adora asked. —The rumours aren't good…

—What are they saying?— Glimmer asked back.

—He disappeared the same day as your aunt… Some say he is a traitor, that he sent her away to the Fright Zone and either escaped or was captured afterwards, and then you have the people who *know* what we told you and think he was *helping her escape* and that the Queen must have him imprisoned… If he's still alive— she replied.

—I heard some mentioning more sorcerers disappeared, and even rumours of… torture— Catra told them, shivering. —Those claims are supported by the fact that, apparently, the Head Sorcerer's horn was found…

—Excuse me!?— Glimmer yelped. —But…

—It's still just a rumour, but I don't think anyone could make that up— she insisted.

—Ok, new rule: we *don't* get involved in this. At all— Bow decided. —Especially if any of that is true.

—I can't believe the knights of Mystacor would allow that…— Glimmer let out, her voice on the verge of breaking. —I can't believe *Dad* would!

—I'm with Bow on that. He may not know— Adora pointed out.

—Then he better find out soon and do *something* about it. Or *I will* get involved— she decided, determined.

—Maybe… *you* don't need to— Catra considered. Glancing back at Adora, she proposed —What if *we* send Shadow Weaver a letter?

—Saying…?

—We can tell her our theories, she may have some information that confirms or denies them.

—Oh! And if it's true and she's being falsely accused, we could make that public!— Adora realized.

—Wait— Bow stopped her. —How would you do that?

—The school's newspaper?

—Well, the students who keep annoying Sparkles *are* from the newspaper. It's not impossible— Catra smirked.

—A-alright— Glimmer sighed. —Let's start slow. Ask the Dark Lord about those theories first. Then… we can see what to do, if anything.

—You were more determined a moment ago— Adora pointed out.

—Yes, I just…— she hesitantly replied. —I think I still can't decide whether I'm more angry or scared…

Chapter End Notes

Well! That was it for today!!

I shall see you next week with the following chapter, and hopefully, in a better mood…

Many thanks for reading!! (#^_^#)

Chapter 8

Chapter Summary

And decisions must be made…

Chapter Notes

Ok, welcome back!!

I've been working on the end of the year fic, so I'm super tired, plus all the drama with the dog, and… stuff…

So, yeah, I hope u like this chapter <3
~~Castaweaver goes brrr at last~~

See the end of the chapter for more notes

That same afternoon, once Castaspella finally had lunch, Shadow Weaver thought she'd immediately go back to the lab.

However, she first asked her for a moment.

—Do you need to talk?

—Something like that— the young woman replied, looking away shyly. —Would you, uh, walk with me?

—Sure— the Dark Lord smirked. —Gardens?

—Yes— she smiled, taking the hand Shadow Weaver offered.

They silently made their way to the gardens, and once sure they were alone, as Castaspella wasn't starting herself, she encouraged her —So? What did you want to talk about?

—I… don't mean to sound ungrateful, but I wanted to know why you… take such good care of me.

—That again?

—It's not the same— the young woman denied. —Or at least, it doesn't feel the same anymore— she explained, squeezing Shadow Weaver's hand.

—Ah… I see— the Dark Lord sighed. —First answer me this: Are you asking whether I have feelings for you, or is this you *not believing* someone can care about you?

—Huh!?— Castaspella uttered, halting in place. —I-I- No- Well…

—I need you to be clear— the old woman insisted, turning to look at her. Right after, taking her other hand in hers, she added —If it's the second, I'll have to give you a longer answer.

Castaspella's face went red up to her ears, and only got worse as she heard the Dark Lord snicker.

—I-I think- I guess… It-it might… be both?

—Is it? That makes it harder for me to reply— Shadow Weaver sighed, pretending to be annoyed. However, she immediately smirked and pulled Castaspella's hands closer to her. —What about giving you a short answer?— she proposed, their faces merely a palm away.

—Please, don't tease me about this…— Castaspella uttered, looking away.

—Who says I'm teasing you?

—That stupid mask— the retorted, squinting back at her.

With no more than a chuckle, Shadow Weaver let go of her hands, took off her mask, and wrapped an arm around the young woman, pulling her closer.

—Am I still teasing?

—You most definitely are, but at least now I can see your smirk— Castaspella replied, pouting exaggeratedly.

—Stop being a baby, will you?— the Dark Lord grunted, rolling her eyes before cupping the young woman's face with her free hand and pulling her closer. —Last chance to stop me.

Castaspella couldn't help the smile that escaped her lips before pushing forward herself to kiss Shadow Weaver.

The young woman threw her arms around the Dark Lord, feeling her legs weaken the longer the kiss lasted, and before she knew it, Shadow Weaver had lifted her from the ground and walked her to the nearest bench.

Sitting there, they broke the kiss barely a moment to breath.

Chuckling, Castaspella took deep breaths yet kept her face close to the older woman's, wanting to continue as soon as she recovered.

On the other hand, Shadow Weaver smirked, out of breath too but hiding it better. She wanted to keep kissing the young woman as well, but hesitated since she knew she wouldn't stop there if Castaspella didn't put a stop to her.

And something told her she wouldn't.

As expected, they were soon kissing again, eventually getting handsy.

A garden is never a good or comfortable place to have sex, but they were a bit caught up in the moment to think about it. Only Castaspella had a few seconds of hesitation, fearing anyone walk in on them… but her arousal had its own logic about it.

Hence, before they knew it, they were laying on the grass, taking turns to please each other without fully removing their clothes; the young woman was rough and thirsty, while Shadow Weaver was perhaps too gentle and seemed to revere every single scar she found around Castaspella's body.

As they finally rested together, recovering their breath, the young woman sighed deeply.

—You… don't need to be careful with me, you know?

—I want to.

—Well, yes, but… I promise I'm not fragile, my wounds have healed… I can take it if you put a little pressure— she smirked.

—Maybe eventually I will— the Dark Lord replied, eyes closed as she took a deep breath.

—Good…

—Now, we both need a bath— she then said, managing to make Castaspella laugh.

—Oh, I'm sure.

—Care to join me?

—Please— the young woman sighed. —But…

—Yes?

—I have something I need to make clear… *before* we go any further.

—Serious talk, huh?

—Yes.

—The other day… when you chose war over returning me…— she began, sitting up. —I was actually going to say "I think I love you"— she admitted, with a brief chuckle. —And… while now I can say it with confidence, I-I need you to promise never to say it back.

—Huh?

—Don't- I mean, don't say the exact phrase "I love you", please— she clarified.

—Is that… related to your mother saying it?

—Yes— she admitted, looking down. —She said it a lot, always as some sort of excuse for everything she did.

—You don't need to explain anything else— Shadow Weaver assured her, placing a hand on her shoulder and tidying up her clothes a bit. —Any other specific phrases?

—Two more, yes— she immediately nodded. —Never, please *never* tell me something that hurts me is "for my own good" or- I know you've said you'd never hurt me, but please, if you ever do, don't say that you do it because you love me.

—Deal— the Dark Lord promised. —Hopefully there won't be any need for me to say such things *but*, if I ever say them…— she began, moving her hand to cup Castaspella's face. —Don't hesitate — she then firmly stated. —If you feel threatened by me, *kill me*.

—I-I…

—Casta, I can't guarantee my behaviour— she insisted. —But I can give you permission to make sure you'll never have to suffer again like you have.

Sniffing and on the verge of tears, Castaspella threw her arms around the Dark Lord, who immediately teleported them both to her room for a very deserved bath…

Later, feeling refreshed, relaxed, and happy, the young woman let Shadow Weaver take her to have dinner.

She had the feeling everyone in the fortress already knew, but… that wasn't many people anyways…

—My Lord— the short man called, arriving with something.

Castaspella felt bad for not knowing his name, but right then, the fact that he carried something like a letter worried her a bit more and she couldn't ask.

—I got… a letter? Hopefully not another war declaration…— she joked.

—No, it's from Salineas. From *them*.

—Oh… Must be important. They never write— Shadow Weaver commented. Castaspella was immensely curious, but wouldn't dare ask about it, so she only waited for the Dark Lord to make any further comments. —Hah! I should have known… Tell me something.

—Me?

—Is there anyone else with us right now?— she asked, unamused.

The man had left already and she hadn't noticed.

Oops…

—So-sorry. What is it?

—Do you have a niece?

—I… think? I should- No, yeah. Of course. Micah had a daughter many years ago— Castaspella finally confirmed.

—I know— she smirked.

—Why did you ask, then?

—I wanted to confirm precisely this: You don't know her, do you?

—No…— Castaspella admitted, looking away. —I just… I *think* her name is Glimmer.

—Well, two girls who used to live here now go to school with her— Shadow Weaver began. —Glimmer is aware of your… disappearance. And the war, of course.

—She must think…

—Let me finish— the Dark Lord interrupted. —No, she does *not* think anything, and in fact, only suspects you escaped from your mother for good reasons…

—Huh?

—These girls I mention, Adora and Catra, want to confirm her theory— she explained. —I'm pretty sure this is Adora writing for them both… Anyways, the thing is: should I or should I not let *them*, hence your niece, know the truth about your mother?

—I-I'm not sure…

—Why is that?

—What if she tells her parents?

—I can simply give them limited information and ask them not to divulge it…

—I don't know. I- It's not that I don't trust your girls, but… what if telling them the truth puts them in danger?

—Well, they are all pretty much as far form Mystacor as possible- Wait.

—What?

As she re-read the letter, Shadow Weaver's smirked widened.

—Oh, I see…

—What is it?

—Glimmer seems to have a memory, they say she's not sure how true it is, about her mother, Queen Angella, saying she'd be safe in Salineas School… That's why they have this theory.

—Angella… knows?— Castaspella asked, breathless. —And she did *nothing*?

—Hold on. Don't jump to conclusions…

—Listen: I don't care. It doesn't matter— she sentenced, standing from the table. —Tell them, if you want, but… I think I need a moment.

—Casta, wait— the Dark Lord called, but was ignored.

Meanwhile, that same night, an *accident* occurred in Bright Moon.

The backroom of the infirmary, where the healers usually crafted medicine and conducted research, caught fire.

No one knew what happened, two healers died… and the results of the vial the Queen wanted analyzed were never reported back to her…

Castaspella finally returned to her room after spending maybe an hour with the three experts trying to craft the damned cure for her father.

She had just laid back on the door, letting out a long sigh, when knocking startled her.

—Huh!? Sha-Shadow Weaver!?— she reacted, blushing immediately. —What… a-are you doing… here?

—Didn't I tell you…

—Be-Beatrix, yes. Sorry— she smiled, sheepish, her cheeks burning as she remembered when she asked her to use that name… during their shower together.

—Alright. To answer your question, I brought you dinner since you had none…— she began. —And, uh, I couldn't tell you, but you're… invited to, uh, my room. To spend… the night, I mean.

—Oh?— she hummed, smiling amusedly.

—Not just tonight, I mean… from now on— she then clarified. —But, I want you to know this will remain your room— she then clarified. —It's important that you have a space that is solely yours…

—Thank you…— Castaspella gently said, accepting the bowl of food. —Would you mind coming in?

—I- Ahem… Sure— she accepted, clearing her throat.

—I needed to tell you something, but wasn't sure about bothering you now…

—I'm sure it's no bother. Speak— the Dark Lord ordered.

—Well… I guess I'm- I think I never told you… everything— she hesitantly began.

—What do you mean?

—About what my mother did to me, but also about what I did to myself…

Shadow Weaver immediately took the bowl from Castaspella's hands, placed it on the night stand, and took her to sit on the bed, looking directly into her eyes.

—Look at me— she ordered. —That's in the past. I won't let her hurt you anymore— she reminded her. —But… if you have any need to hurt yourself, *do* tell me.

—That's the thing…— she sighed. —I made the joke about earning weight here, but now that I *am*… I-I've been having this need to do what my mother would…

—The corsets you mentioned?

—That or tight belts, or sashes… Anything that can… you know…

—Why do you feel the need to tighten your body like that?

—Be-because- I-I don't know…— Castaspella sniffed. —You had the tailor make clothes that actually fit me, but I feel- I-I think I just see myself too… *too big*.

—I see…— Shadow Weaver sighed, pulling her into an embrace. —Listen… it won't be easy to stop feeling like that. But I promise you: you're fine. You look *healthy* now.

The young woman tried to hold back her tears, but it was impossible. She finally broke and cried in full earnest, clinging onto the Dark Lord as if her life depended on it.

—Thank you…— she finally muttered, raising her head again.

—Nothing to thank me for. Just eat— she insisted.

—Right…— Castaspella accepted reaching for the bowl. —Would you keep me company, though?

—As long as I have nothing else to do…— she smirked. —Why don't you tell me how the research for the cure is going?

—Oh, sure…— she accepted, munching on her food. —Zacharias… explained how to test… the first cure prototype.

—Mhmm…

—The problem… is we haven't found… the original poison!— Castaspella went on, noticeably hungry by the speed she was eating at. —So, I proposed… a more general… cure! Something that… would work with any of those… um, poisons.

—Smart.

—Really?— she asked, looking back with a shine in her eyes.

—Yes, really— Shadow Weaver laughed. —But that will probably take more time.

—Yes… The formula isn't easy, and we'd have to make enough for a fully grown man like my father…— she sighed, setting the bowl back on the nightstand.

Pensive, the Dark Lord was looking down, considering how she could maybe help, when there was a knock on the door. Castaspella immediately went to open, and it was that short man again.

Well, now she couldn't ask his name, but because she was too ashamed.

—Oh, evening, Castaspella— he said, bowing his head. —I was told the Dark Lord is here.

—Yes, she brought me food…

—What is it?— the old woman immediately asked, appearing behind her.

—I apologize, My Lord, but we've got news from Bright Moon…

—What happened!?— Castaspella exclaimed, worried.

—There was a fire. We can’t identify where from here, but it looks… bad. The apothecary says it’s chemical from the colour of the smoke.

—Any casualties?— Shadow Weaver asked, serious.

—None reported yet, but…

—But?

—Zacharias has a bad feeling…

—Huh… so someone did die, yet no one important enough to announce it— the Dark Lord concluded. —Anything about what caused the fire?

—We’ve sent someone to gather information, but we have no news yet.

—Inform me as soon as they return.

—Of course, My Lord— he nodded, bowing deeply before retiring.

—Well, that’s quite suspicious…— Shadow Weaver snickered. —I still have to reply to Adora. I’ll ask if they know anything about the fire— she decided.

—Oh, about that— Castaspella remembered. —You can tell them… the truth. I don’t mind. But tell them to be careful too…

—I shall.

Chapter End Notes

Well, that was it!
I'm so sorry my notes aren't more elaborate today, but, well… Idk

Many thanks for reading, ofc, and see you next week!! :D

Chapter 9

Chapter Summary

The reckoning draws closer…

Chapter Notes

I apologize, I almost forgot to post this today! Oops!!

I forgot it was Wednesday <(“^_^)

Now! It’s time for some *revelations*!

XD I hope u like today’s chapter!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The following day, in Salineas Alliance School, the courier arrived early.

A single black envelope stood out among the regular white or brown ones, and Adora rushed to get it.

—Why is she always so extra?— Catra asked, snickering.

—I did find it quickly, didn’t I?

—Fair point…

—Alright, let’s find Glimmer and read this— Adora proposed.

Around noon, Micah was back in Mystacor, checking on his father, who hadn’t opened his eyes yet. He seemed conscious, but he couldn’t speak nor did he react in any way other than brief spasms.

—Please, Father…— he muttered, holding his hand while sitting next to the bed, and letting his tears fall. —I can’t help you alone…

Not after his only hope to find a cure went up in flames…

Sighing deeply, he held the King’s hand between his as he stared at the window.

—Micah?— his mother suddenly called, walking into the room. —He isn’t waking up, is he?

—No…

—I'm so sorry, my dear Son— she told him, kneeling to embrace him. —And I heard there was… a fire last night?

—Yes.

—It must have been the Dark Lord's people. They surely don't want you to find the cure for your father— she scoffed, looking away.

—So you are saying they have free access to *all* our kingdoms!?

—Calm down. I'm sure it's not "free access" exactly, but rather… they probably have supporters who have done… all of this. It's a question of finding and punishing them— she nodded.

—Right…

—But you don't need to worry, my Dear— she then said, standing up. —Before collapsing, your father laid out a sound plan with the knights. We'll recover your sister soon— she assured him.

—Really?

—Yes. You simply don't worry anymore about that, alright? Focus on your father— she told him, squeezing his shoulder.

—Thank you, Mother— he replied with a weak tone.

That exact moment, he recalled Angella's expression when she took the vial.

It had been like she was trying to hide the fact that they *would* analyze it.

But why?

If it really was because his mother couldn't be trusted… if *she* had done this, then he had to stay by his father until he woke up, lest she finished the job…

Soon, the Queen of Mystacor was in front of Norwyn, looking a bit too cocky for his taste.

—You still wish to keep betting on them?

—You could have gotten your own son killed!

—As if…— Akane scoffed, rolling her eyes. —I didn't, because *he* trusts me.

—But Angella doesn't— Norwyn reminded her.

—And one day I shall *burn her wings* for it!— Akane barked back, slamming the bars of his cell.

—You should be careful, your Majesty— he ominously replied.

—Sure…— she smirked, finally walking away.

She had only visited him to flex about her “power”, hadn’t she?

Norwyn looked at his hands, wounded from trying and failing to break free.

She must have put something on the vial, knowing Queen Angella would have it analyzed at any cost…

If only he could do *something* to let Micah know…

Later that day, Shadow Weaver called Castaspella to read with her the reply from Adora.

It appeared that Glimmer had also gotten a letter from her mother that morning, hence they could relay what they knew about the fire; Angella hadn’t explicitly said it, but they were sure the “mysterious substance” being analyzed was the poison that hurt the King of Mystacor.

In short, they understood, they were also searching for a cure in Bright Moon, and got sabotaged.

The only reason they called it an accident, was because they didn’t want Queen Akane calling it an attack from Shadow Weaver… Which led to the question of *why* was Angella doing this.

—She’s certainly not protecting me— the Dark Lord immediately said. —Either this is to stay away from the war… or she’s protecting *you*— she told Castaspella.

—Sure…— she sighed.

—On the other hand, there’s the proposal of the girls, about publishing the truth in the School’s newspaper.

—You think that would do any good?

—It would certainly do a lot of *bad* to your mother— Shadow Weaver smirked. —But I understand your hesitation. It would put a spotlight on you.

—Yeah…

—Then it’s your choice. I’ll reply in a few hours so they get the letter tonight. You can think better about it in the meantime.

—No need— Castaspella suddenly replied, raising her head. Looking at her with determination, she added —I’ll write it all out myself. They can simply post the letter.

Shadow Weaver smirked wickedly, proud, and passed her pen and paper.

—Be my guest.

Night fell and the last few letters arrived at Salineas Alliance School.

Another black envelope waited for the girls, but also a fancy one that Adora correctly guessed came from Bright Moon.

She took them both and found her friends, who waited for her in Glimmer's room.

—Which one do we open first?— Catra asked.

—Well, I asked Mom about the fire… That may be shorter— the princess proposed.

—Yeah, the- uh, the black envelope looks quite thick— Bow pointed out.

—Alright, go ahead then, Sparkles.

Taking a deep breath, she opened her mother's letter and first read it silently.

—Oh…— she sighed. —So… "The fire wasn't an accident, but I can't tell you more details. Not if I want to keep you safe from all this mess"— she first read. —"I promise you that we shall handle this. Your aunt and your grandfather will be fine…"

—You know your mother better, Glim. Do you think she's just trying to keep you from panicking or she means it?

—Not… sure. But…— Glimmer sighed, shaking her head. —Let me see something— she then said, and summoned her powers. —Turn off the lights— she asked Adora, who was closer to the switch. And as she did, her theory proved right. —We used to play secret messages with Mom…— she explained, showing them the glowing text in the letter. —She hid her true message for me to… find.

—Sparkles, that doesn't look good— Catra uttered, eyes wide.

—"Queen Akane gave your father the supposed poison. It was just inflammable liquid. Two healers died, the physicians are hurt. You father is having a crisis"— Adora read aloud.

—"I can't do anything else without risking you or your father"— Bow sighed, reading the last sentence.

—Then… what do we do?— Glimmer asked, on the verge of tears. —I can't sit here and watch them all- I-I have to do something!

—I'm sorry, Glim— Bow hugged her, letting her cry in his shoulder. —But if you act without a plan, you'll put yourself in danger and your mom…

—I know— she sobbed. Sniffing and brushing away her tears after letting go of Bow, she asked —Can we open your letter now, guys?

—Yeah— Adora nodded, turning the lights back on. —Oh, it's two letters.

—Let's read this one first— Catra proposed, recognizing Shadow Weavers handwriting. —Mhmm, mhmm… Okay, this is kinda… terrible— she let out, her expression growing concerned the further she read. —So, that other letter is from… your aunt, Sparkles. She… explains everything— she first revealed, looking at Adora who handed the letter to the princess. —The Dark Lord says we have permission to post that letter on the newspaper, but also warns us to be careful, and… well, your aunt is also searching for a cure for your grandad. We shouldn't mention that last part just in case though, lest the Queen of Mystacor learns about it and… kills him.

—Guys…— Glimmer uttered, her lower lip trembling. —If all of this is true…

—Can I see?— Bow asked, taking the letter from her shaky hands. After a moment skimming through it, the boy went pale. —Are we sure this… can be posted on the newspaper? It's really… gritty.

—That may mean they will give it even more exposure— Catra considered, aloof for a second, before letting them see how concerned she really was. —And maybe, by posting that, Queen Akane will lose her power.

—She better— Glimmer scoffed, angry now. —I'll write back to Mom in the morning, you get the newspaper-snobs my aunt's letter, and Bow…

—Yes?

—Can you write to your dads?

—Sure. What about?— he then asked.

—Ask them for rumours; anything being said on that side of the sea, about the war, about Mystacor, Bright Moon, and the Fright Zone.

—That may be a long list of rumours.

—I know— she nodded. —But being here, we are both safe and *ignorant*. I can't stay ignorant.

—Spoken like a true princess— Catra smirked.

It took some convincing, but they were right and the morbidness of Castaspella's letter made the newspaper editors work all night to get it posted for their morning edition.

They were sure it would cause yet another uproar the following day, so the people who knew, got ready…

At the same time, Castaspella was pulling an all-nighter with the three experts, testing different formulas.

Failure, failure, failure…

They had about eleven versions to test, and the closer they got to the last one, the worse Castaspella felt.

But then… the ninth version succeeded!

They tested the last two just in case, but it was definitely the ninth version.

Now, it was time to start synthesizing enough for a grown man like her father…

—Excuse me, Castaspella— Zacharias called. —I suppose you haven't noticed, but it's morning already— he gently explained. —I suggest you go to rest while we handle the synthesis.

—Morning!? Oh…— she reacted. —I hadn't noticed… But then, you all should rest too.

—Don’t worry about it. We’ll take turns to look over the process and get some sleep— the alchemist assured her.

—Alright. Thank you *very much*. All of you— she bowed.

—Thank *you* for the trust— the apothecary replied, as they three bowed back.

With that, Castaspella retired to her room, took a quick bath, and passed out in bed as soon as she laid down.

She was much calmer.

Finding the cure gave her some peace, and hope…

Just as she went to sleep, across the sea in Salineas Alliance School, the newspaper was being delivered.

The couriers had… quite a busy morning. And they suspected it’d be like that all day.

Regardless, in the middle of the chaos caused by the published letter, Bow’s fathers’ letter arrived.

As soon as he got it, the teen went to find his friends and handed the letter to Glimmer.

—Bow, your fathers are adorable— she began, giggling, and making him blush. —Anyways, these are really a lot of rumours, but… here’s what I’m interested in— she explained, smoothing the paper over a table and taking out a pen to underline the important rumours.

—They are recruiting…— Adora muttered. —So Mystacor is preparing for war but… Shadow Weaver isn’t.

—It’s clear she has no intentions to fight or attack, at the very least.

—Yeah, no, she will defend and only attack if provoked seriously— Catra confirmed.

—Well, here’s the other thing: Bright Moon seems to be refusing to help them and that’s sparking rumours about the accident being Mystacor’s fault— Glimmer smirked.

—You really know your stuff, Glim— Bow smiled.

—I’m studying this right now, so I thought I’d put it into practice— she proudly nodded. —Last thing: all these rumours about Head Sorcerer Norwyn are a mess, but this here…

—Sorcerers from the guild are joining… the knights!?— he gasped.

—Fear— Glimmer sighed. —They are *afraid*.

Chapter End Notes

Alright! That’s all for today!!

I hope u liked the chapter, and hopefully are hyped for the upcoming DISASTER!

Sorry hahah I promise it will be interesting! :D

See you next week! Ch10 will be ready, I promise!!

Thank you for reading!

Chapter 10

Chapter Notes

HECK! I FORGOT!
~~Let's pretend nothing happened...~~

Oooooohhhhhhhhh at last! We're almost there! You'll soon witness the true power of Shadow Weaver, the Dark Lord!

But first, lemme introduce a new character (not new at all, it's an old OC that has already appeared plenty XD) as things prepare for *the* moment!!!

Also, you'll now see the true extent of Akane's influence and wickedness (._.)

Anyways! Not gonna distract you anymore, please enjoy!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Ch 10

When Castaspella woke up, it was already noon.

She felt refreshed, for once, and quite hungry, so she immediately got changed and headed to the dining room.

—Afternoon…— the Dark Lord greeted her, monotonous enough for it to sound normal.

—Good afternoon— Castaspella replied, in a notoriously good mood. —I forgot to tell you, before going to sleep, that…

—You found a cure, yes. I've been notified— the old woman nodded. —I have news for you, but you should eat first.

—Oh… Well, you shouldn't have told me you had news. Now I want to know— she pointed out.

—Patience— Shadow Weaver replied, standing up. As she moved to sit closer to Castaspella, leaving a newspaper opened on the table where she was before, she gestured at the servants on standby. —We'll have lunch, or breakfast for you, and then I'll tell you everything.

—Oh, this is about the publication, isn't it?

The Dark Lord just stared at her for a moment in silence.

When Castaspella made a pout and folded her arms, she smirked and let out —I won't say a thing, no matter if you beg.

—Fine! Then I'll eat quickly!

—No, you will enjoy your food and when we're *both* done, I'll tell you— Shadow Weaver insisted.

—Why are you doing this?— the young woman complained.

—I have let you work all night and sleep all morning. I let it pass that you didn't apply the unguent for your scars. Now I'm making sure you eat properly before you do anything else.

—Mean…

—I prefer "strict"— she smirked.

Castaspella still rushed a bit, but at least Shadow Weaver managed to delay it half an hour before she finally showed her the newspaper and the letter from Adora and Catra.

She also had a report regarding the incident in Bright Moon, and another on the condition of Mystacor's King.

—Alright, so… So, they are preparing— the young woman began, trying to summarize it all. —Bright Moon won't help, people think the fire incident was Mystacor's fault, and… my niece says

the sorcerers are joining the knights… out of fear?

—Pretty much, yes.

—My father is still unconscious, so the knights answer directly to my mother…

—Indeed.

—Do you think they will attack soon?— Castaspella then asked, supporting herself on the table but looking up at Shadow Weaver.

—Possibly. However, the Queen's credibility is already falling, just not fast enough— she replied. —That means she'll try to attack today before she loses all her power… Or, of course, she could attempt to regain her power *before* attacking. That may give us more time— she then considered.

—Basically, you *don't know* if they will attack soon. Got it.

The Dark Lord's unamused expression, far from scaring her, made Castaspella giggle.

—It's not- What I meant to say is that the Queen *will* act soon, yes. But whether that's attacking or not, I can't tell— she explained. —Why don't you tell me about her strategies a bit, so we can figure this out?

—Listen, I don't… know… I don't understand much… of *that*— the young woman admitted, looking down.

—I see…— Shadow Weaver nodded. She could only imagine what was going through Castaspella's head right now, and much to her dismay, all she wanted to do now, was distract her from all of this. Some Dark Lord she was… —Alright. I propose you take advantage of the day. Since there's a chance Mystacor will attack today, I believe you should enjoy the peace while it lasts.

—I-I suppose you're right— she nodded, still looking down.

The old woman rolled her eyes at her own reaction to Castaspella's sorrow, and took a deep breath.

She had to put in some work, it seemed.

—Since you've still been here for such a *short* time…— she began, looking away. —I guess I could… take you around? Uh, you could…

—Yes— Castaspella immediately accepted, looking back at her. She was on the verge of tears. —Please…

—Alright… Come on, then— she sighed, extending her hand invitingly. As soon as she took it, Shadow Weaver pulled her close and whispered —Say it.

—I love you— the young woman smiled.

—So do I.

That afternoon, in Mystacor, the Queen spent a few hours discussing with her son.

—You can't seriously believe what that newspaper says…

—It's Esmeralda's handwriting!

—So what!? The Dark Lord may have forced her to write all of that!

—Why would she!?— he insisted, increasingly indignant.

—For this exact purpose! Don't you see!? This makes people *question me*, including you!— Akane scoffed. —My own son doubts me now!

Closing his fists tightly and looking away, he considered how, in fact, he was already doubting her before… This only *confirmed* he was right to doubt her.

But he wouldn't let her know.

—Mother, listen to me: I'm just asking you to call off the war for now. Let's try diplomacy again— he said.

—It was *you* who jumped to declare war, my Dear, not me…

—But now you're in charge of the knights. Just tell them to-to stand by. Alright?

—And what reason do I give them?— she insisted, holding back a smirk.

—That-that… Uh, just give me some time. Te-tell them that Bright Moon will help, but they need to wait for the reinforcements… until *tomorrow*!— he finally decided.

—Oh, alright. I see— his mother nodded. —I will speak with the knights, then, but I want those reinforcements ready first thing in the morning— she then told him, severe. —You should know already that ruling a kingdom isn't an easy job, and if I were to lie to my knights, then who would protect Mystacor?

—I understand, Mother— he sighed. —Just give me until tomorrow, and I'll march to the Fright Zone myself— he promised.

—Very well, my Son.

With that, he walked away, thinking about how exactly he would handle it the following day.

Should he demand answers and only threaten to attack? Should he come up with some excuse to keep delaying the attack?

Maybe he had to speak with his wife.

Angella would know what to do.

However, as soon as Queen Akane saw her son far away enough, with no signs of returning, she ordered for her generals to meet her.

Within minutes, they were all there in the throne room.

The ones loyal to her husband and the kingdom, and the ones… loyal to her *alone*.

She told them what Micah had promised, gave the order to stand by, and then dismissed them with a peculiar phrase.

—I hereby trust you with Mystacor's future.

The generals saluted and retired, leaving her alone for a few minutes, until three of them returned.

—My Queen— the one in the middle saluted, bowing deeply. —Your orders.

—Where are the other two?

—Apologies, your Majesty. They seem to have been rising suspicions lately and couldn't attend.

—Then you'll have to rely this information to them— she severely said. —I want you all to get ready to depart tonight.

—How many soldiers should we take?

—Ten each, should suffice— Akane considered. —You know what you must do.

—Yes, your Majesty.

—Ah, and take *all* the new recruits. Divide them among you; with a couple of capable knights in each of your squads you should be fine.

—Understood. At your service, your Majesty— the general replied, all three bowing deeply now.

The five generals of the Queen met a few hours later, after the sun disappeared behind the horizon.

As instructed, they called all the new recruits, assigned them to one of the squads, and then gathered their trusted underlings. Each team had two or three of their best men, and between seven and nine of the new arrivals.

The cannon fodder.

With little training and all the fear in the world, the rookies followed their assigned general in silence as they made their way to the Fright Zone.

They were confused, however, as they weren't proudly marching to war but rather… sneaking in.

The new recruits were mostly sorcerers; not all of them, but the majority, they realized. They kept exchanging glances, hoping someone would reassure them…

No one did.

The veterans of the squads remained silent and focused, they did *not* spare them a glance.

And the generals?

They wanted to ask them what exactly was going on, but they were terrified of these high-ranking knights.

Yet it would all soon be clear.

Once they stepped into Fright Zone territory, the generals each took a different path.

The squad headed towards the east soon found a waste drainage outlet; that was their way into the citadel.

Feeling too uncomfortable in the armour, one of the rookies, a sorcerer, considered dropping everything and running away.

But it was as if the general read his thoughts.

—You— he called, pointing at him. —Go in first.

—Me!?

—Are you questioning my order?

—No, Sir. Right away, Sir— he uttered, shaking but still obeying. He had joined because he knew he wouldn't last long without the Head Sorcerer to protect him… and because there may be someone he knew here in the Fright Zone. If he marched to war, he had a chance of deserting and finding this person. But if they were sneaking in like this, what hope did he have to ever escape? — What- Ho-how do I know which way to go?— he then asked, upon reaching a branching in the sewer.

There were now three possible paths.

After a moment of consideration, the general ordered —Continue ahead. It's our best shot.

Meanwhile, on the other side of the citadel, two squads had already gotten inside and were heading for the fortress through different paths.

Despite the armour, they hardly made any sound, so they had no trouble reaching the gardens.

However, there were some people tending to the flower-patches, talking amongst themselves, who would certainly notice such big groups, even in the darkness.

The first squad that arrived was ordered to crouch and wait; the general only had to gesture at the two veterans for them to understand, and they silently separated from the group.

The second squad arrived soon enough, continued towards the inside of the fortress without stopping, and paid no attention to the people near the flower-patches.

After all, they were all dead already.

Soon enough, four of the squads were inside the fortress.

The place was a maze and looked a bit haunted…

The generals had expected to find more people inside, even assuming most had to be sleeping, so being met with utter silence and desolation made them a bit cocky.

Without a word, they sent their veterans ahead and gestured at the new ones to stay silent and follow them.

Each squad moved through the halls, finding no obstructions, yet still on high alert at first.

Little by little, the generals began to relax, and only the new recruits kept clutching their weapons and looking around in fear, still oblivious to what the veterans were doing.

And perhaps it was better if they didn't know yet.

The last squad to arrive was the one walking through the waste drainage.

They eventually emerged inside the fortress, without the faintest idea of where they were, and their general sent the veterans of the squad away with a wave of his hand.

Then, with a silent gesture, he ordered the new recruits to follow him quietly.

Everything was shrouded in darkness, the silence was absolute, and the temperature seemed lower.

Shaking, the hesitant sorcerer walked behind the general, wishing he wasn't there.

He had been sent first because he was expendable.

He knew it…

However, he was so absorbed by his thoughts that he didn't notice when the general stopped, and crashed against him, their armours rattling loudly, if only for a second.

—So-sorry…

—Idiot!— the general spat, keeping his voice low. He then looked back as a light turned on inside a chamber they had just walked by, and immediately ordered —Go check. And *eliminate* whoever is there.

Eliminate!?

Was that… his only option!?

He wanted to refuse, he wanted to run away, but the general grabbed him by the arm and pushed him towards the door.

The squad kept walking without looking back, and left him there.

Alone.

He had no choice but to get into the chamber and… kill?

Maybe he could just… surrender? But what if *he* got killed instead!?

Still shaking, the sorcerer in knight armour opened the door to the chamber and readied his weapon…

—Huh!?— he uttered, seeing a single man standing in the middle of the otherwise-empty room, his eyes covered. He had to be *blind*. And he seemed to be… waiting for him? —What!?— he gasped, as realization hit.

—I knew the lights would attract you— the man smiled. He could swear he recognized that smile… —And I'm glad it's you alone.

—Who-who are you!?— he asked, despite the air of familiarity.

—Don't you recognize me?— Zacharias asked, sensing his unease. —Have I changed that much?

—Wait… This can't be you. You-you died!

No, he knew that wasn't true, but it *was* the official story. For some reason, it was the first thing that came to mind.

—You're wearing a knight armour, aren't you? I'm just as surprised, Nolrem— he replied, a bit mocking.

—Shush, shush— the sorcerer rushed to silence him, looking back at the door. —These people are *dangerous*. I can't- If they return…

—I can handle them— Zacharias assured him. —But there's so much silence… Don't tell me you sneaked in…

—Yes…— Nolrem admitted, feeling ashamed. —There are four other squads. If they are already here… Well, I'm starting to suspect they are.

—Oh, I understand— he nodded, his expression darkening. —I need you to listen to me: take off that armour, immediately, and then follow me— the physician ordered.

—What? But…

—Trust me; I don't know how much time you have left, so be quick.

—Time left? Before what?

—Before the Dark Lord discovers the intrusion, of course.

He said it so matter-of-factly that it shocked Nolrem for a moment.

What did that even mean!?

Nothing good, he was sure.

—Alright, alright— he finally accepted, unfastening the pieces of the armour as fast as he could. — But I don't think much can be done now. The general ordered me… *to kill you*. Most of us just joined, but if the veteran knights that came with us were given the same orders, then maybe…

—They have silently killed everyone they found… yes— Zacharias nodded. Right after, he helped Nolrem with the last pieces of armour and immediately grabbed his hand, pulling him along. — Leave everything there, it doesn't matter.

—Where are you taking me?

—Somewhere safe, don't worry— he assured him, casting a spell that revealed a secret door. — This will get ugly really fast, and you're *not* ready for this, Nolrem.

Chapter End Notes

:D ehe

Get ready
Cause you, like Nolrem, are *not* ready for what comes next week :|

In any case XD Thanks for reading!! See you (#^_^#)

Chapter 11

Chapter Notes

Oh, at last!
I had been wanting to post this chapter for so long, my gods…

In any case, it's finally here, so I sure hope u enjoy! :D

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Ch 11

The alchemist was just finishing her work for the night, bottling up the cure for the King of Mystacor, when she noticed the emergency entrance about to open.

—Is that you, Zack?

—I bring company— he warned her, before stepping into the laboratory. —I can't explain quick enough, so just seal the door… Wait, where did *they* go? I told you both to stay here.

—Just went out to collect some night-blooming flowers…

—Who?— Nolrem asked, before he could stop himself.

—Our apothecary— Zacharias replied, already starting to worry. —But, that means… Oh, no… They…

—What happened and who is this!?— the alchemist interrupted, storing the cure inside a glass cupboard.

—Listen to me. We're in danger— the physician began, bumping against the table on his way to seal the door himself. —The knights of Mystacor are here…

—Huh? But I didn't hear anything!

—*Exactly*.

—He's telling the truth— Nolrem began, nervous. —I was- I came with them…

—What!?

—Easy, I know him— Zacharias interrupted, trying to hide how dishoriented he was. —He's not going to hurt us— he insisted.

—Zack, you're serious— the alchemist realized. —Shouldn't we tell the Dark Lord!?

—You think she doesn't know yet?— the physician nervously laughed. —We both know what comes next. We can only wait now.

—I guess you're right.

—You mean… that woman can really take on more than forty people alone?— Nolrem asked, disbelieving. The alchemist glanced back at Zacharias before they both nodded seriously. —But that's insane!

—Well, if your theory is correct… those knights themselves are giving her all the ammunition she needs— he considered.

—What? What ammunition?

—The dead— the alchemist somberly replied, closing her eyes as realization hit.

Meanwhile, not much earlier, Shadow Weaver and Castaspella were just getting ready to sleep. Freshened up and changed into their night gowns, the women got under the sheets and relaxed back with a long sigh.

—Are you… alright? Bea?— the young woman asked, noticing the Dark Lord's ears twitch. —I wasn't sure before, but you're definitely restless…

—I have the same damned feeling than- I just have a *bad* feeling. I'm paying too much attention to every sound— she explained, deciding against pretending she wasn't anxious. —Do you hear anything?

—Can't say I do…— Castaspella admitted, until a strange knock on the door startled her. —That, I did hear it.

Squinting, Shadow Weaver sat up on the bed for a moment, hesitant.

—Stay there— she ordered, finally deciding to check the door.

Unfortunately, that only made the young woman nervous, throwing reason right out of the window.

She didn't want to stay alone in bed!

But then, when the Dark Lord opened just enough to look outside, she had no time to fret over the sight of the dead man at her doorstep.

A powerful kick pushed her back as the door flew open, and Castaspella barely managed to catch her so she wouldn't fall back on the ground.

—Knights ready!— a voice yelled, prompting the three generals and the knights behind them to position their swords in front of them.

The young woman felt her heart sink as she recognized the armour, yet it was nothing compared to the dread she felt upon seeing the body of the short man whose name she could never ask.

And she finally lost it.

Blinded by despair, she rushed to kneel next to him, hopelessly wishing he wasn't gone yet, regardless of the battle-ready knights being so close.

As she cried in full earnest, Shadow Weaver stood straight, boosting her height with a bit of magic, and slowly approached the generals without the slightest hint of fear.

—Did Mystacor send their strongest? Because you're certainly not the smartest…— she taunted, wanting to draw their attention away from the young woman.

—Surrender, Dark Lord! Your people are dead, and you are *cornered*!

—Am I?— she snickered, her tone mockingly dangerous.

However, her diversion didn't last long as Castaspella's broken voice immediately uttered —*Dead*? They all…

—Return willingly, Princess, and you won't be harmed— one of the generals ordered.

—No— she let out, voice hoarse and eyes wide open. Shaking, she pushed herself up from the ground and backtracked. —I-I am not…

—The Princess you speak about is *gone*— Shadow Weaver interceded. Using her magic to pull the trembling woman behind herself, she went on —*This* is Castaspella, and she's under *my* protection. I won't ask twice: Leave my land, immediately.

—Didn't you listen!? Everyone here is *dead*. You can't with all of us alone— another general scoffed, far too cocky.

Yet she only laughed.

—Everyone!?— she cackled, a hint of insanity tainting her voice. —Well, that's just terrible… *for you*.

While two of the generals simply thought her insane, the one in the middle remained serious.

He could only think of one thing that would likely mean.

And the knights behind them, both veterans and rookies, seemed to hesitate. They had the feeling that this was no laughing matter.

—Are you senile already!?— the cocky general mocked her.

—On the contrary— she smirked. —I'm about to show you… why I'm *the Dark Lord*.

—You wouldn't— the serious general immediately defied her, more like trying to convince himself. —You-your moral code! You-you can't…

—Oh, but I *can*— she interrupted, sparing a glance at her dead servant. —You are obviously unaware, but everyone living here… has *explicitly* agreed to this— she revealed, as her magic started to reanimate the corpse. —We have been ready for this treachery since I took over… and due to how unfair their deaths were…

—No…

—You may have guessed what awaits you now— Shadow Weaver concluded, closing her fist dramatically, right before every reanimated corpse in the fortress let out a screech. The cacophony of haunting screams freezed their blood as the knights realized their number didn't give them *any* advantage. —For the ignorant among you: these are wraths. They will not rest until their unfair deaths are avenged… *Start running*.

The squad that had abandoned Nolrem was still scouting when they heard the chilling wails of the undead.

—The fuck is that?— the general let out as they all stood still, looking around. —You two: check the windows on that side— he then ordered, gesturing at two rookies. —You and you: this other side— he went on. —And you three: get ready. Strike anything that comes to us.

Shaking, the knights did as ordered.

Wholly unprepared for the nightmare that had begun, it wasn't long before they got attacked by shadowy creatures who barely resembled people.

The general yelled orders, the knights tried to obey… yet only two of these creatures were enough to subjugate the remaining squad.

Three of the rookies ran away, dropping their weapons and leaving their general alone with bloodied corpses; he was still standing, sword in hand, sure that his veteran knights would return…

Until he noticed his assailants' wounds.

Cuts on their throats, clearly done from behind.

Stealth kills.

And so he finally realized it: the veterans were already dead.

It was now his turn.

Still in her room, Shadow Weaver held Castaspella tightly while the reanimated short man took down every knight, one by one, until they were all dead or running for their lives.

Once the worst passed, she let go of the young woman.

—Where did he… go?

—To help the rest of the victims get their revenge— the Dark Lord replied. She then brushed away her tears, saying —There isn't much I can do for my people now other than this. But then, they will finally rest for good. You can mourn them, but don't get lost in grief.

—I caused this— Castaspella sniffed, looking away.

—No— Shadow Weaver immediately denied. —You came seeking refuge. We gave it to you. They wouldn't blame you, Casta.

—But…

—Everyone in the fortress worked here because they wanted their families to be safe. They knew the risks and accepted them— she insisted. —The knights will be dealt with soon enough, and then I will handle the outcome. You just need to remain here until it's done.

Castaspella's expression still revealed guilt and shame, but there was now determination there too.

—Let me help— she requested. Looking up at her with fire in her eyes, she insisted —I-I'll help bury them, a-and let their families know what happened. I-I want to honor them in some way…

—It's not your responsibility, but if that's what you want, I won't oppose. It will probably help you too…— Shadow Weaver considered, finally accepting her request. —But don't blame yourself for Queen Akane's treachery.

—She's still my mother…— Castaspella sighed, looking away.

—Blood-ties mean absolutely nothing to her, it's clear, since she's harmed you so much. I don't see why you should take responsibility for her… You're free to cut those ties if you want— the Dark Lord reminded her. —But even if you don't, always keep in mind you're your own person. Not *her belonging*.

Sniffing, the young woman hugged her tightly, muffling her gratitude and renewed crying.

Back inside the sealed lab, the alchemist handed Zacharias a cup of tea, which he went to offer Nolrem. The sorcerer was sitting in a corner, holding back tears, avoiding eye-contact as much as possible.

He was too ashamed.

But the physician still knew him well, despite the years apart, and managed to help him a bit.

—I chose the wrong strategy to escape Mystacor, didn't I?

—You couldn't have known— Zacharias pointed out, sitting next to him.

—I should have done something as soon as Norwyn disappeared— he insisted. —When other sorcerers went missing the next week, it should have been enough for me to drop everything and leave.

—Nolrem, listen to me: do you think that crazy Queen would have allowed you to simply walk away? If you hadn't come here with the knights, you would still be trapped there.

—No, but… I wasn't smart! I was a *coward*!

—At least you survived— the alchemist interrupted, nonchalantly laying against the table as she sipped her tea. —You can't always be brave *and* survive. You do what you can… You're not stupid, you're not selfish, you're just surviving.

—I have trouble seeing it that way— Nolrem admitted, before taking a long sip. —It wasn't so bad for me… I could have- I think I had options before Norwyn was- I just never thought it could happen to me.

—That's normal— Zacharias insisted. —People *normally* think they are safe until something proves them wrong.

—You can ask anyone in this place what their story is, and you'll find no patterns, nothing in common, other than the fact we survived violence from supposedly "safe" people. Even those who only knew violence since the beginning will tell you that they feared the unknown even more at first— the alchemist somberly said. —You may have had options, but you had no reasons to make different choices from the ones you made.

—So… everyone here…

—Most, yes. Mainly adults— Zacharias nodded, guessing his question. —Fortunately, the kids born here have only known peace. It was hard earned, but we know the Dark Lord holds it sacred.

—As long as everyone obeys…— Nolrem muttered.

—Sure, but her demands are rarely unreasonable— the physician insisted. —And we can always refuse to obey if we have good reasons. She's strict, relentless against abusers, but considerate enough too, thanks to Norwyn…

—Huh?

—You probably only heard about her wickedness and some mysterious moral code. It's all true, and it's thanks to that man— the alchemist confirmed. —Keeping her moral code a secret and her air of scary-leader intact is all for our protection.

—I… think I understand now— Nolrem nodded, looking down at his mug.

—Good— Zacharias gently smiled.

—What now?

—Well, it's been a while, I think I can check how everything is outside— the physician considered.

—I'll get you the basin— the alchemist offered.

Nolrem only watched as Zacharias conjured images of the fortress, wanting but not daring to offer his help.

Once they confirmed no threats remained, the lab was unsealed.

—I'll take him to see the Dark Lord, you…

—I'll find them, Zack. Don't worry— the alchemist interrupted, nodding shakily.

Before sunrise, all bodies were counted and separated into Mystacorean knights and servants of the fortress.

Only a handful of servants survived…

And the few rookie knights who were spared, all forfeited their loyalty to Mystacor.

Some even begged to be taken in as servants in exchange for their safety.

Hence, as Shadow Weaver considered it, Castaspella asked her for a minute.

—What is it?— she inquired, looking tired without her mask.

—I think you should take them in…

—I imagined you'd say that.

—With one condition— the young woman clarified. —They must write down their testimonies about tonight.

—You want me to send everything to the girls, don't you?

—I know you were going to let them know anyways, so why don’t we give them something to publish too?

—Smart— Shadow Weaver smirked, grabbing Castaspella's chin. She felt quite proud of her; she wasn’t on high alert all the time, but neither was she taking for granted her current life. She knew she could lose this if she wasn’t careful, and took measures to avoid that. Hence, she felt confident enough to make a bold promise to her. —We’ll give Akane’s crumbling power the final blow— she swore, pulling her closer. —You’ll finally be free— she then concluded, right before kissing her deeply.

Chapter End Notes

Alright, no idea what else to put in this note tbh, I'm feeling under the weather despite my excitement for this chapter

So! I hope you enjoyed, thanks for reading, and I'll see you next week with (hopefully) the last chapter!!

Chapter 12

Chapter Notes

Hi, guys, welcome back!

So, this final chapter had to be divided after all, I'm *so sorry*, and I probably must mention there's some… uh, glossed over self-harm part near the end? I swear it's nothing super explicit…
Honestly, I made myself cry with this chapter…

Oh well, I still hope you enjoy this chapter!! :D

PS.: I include a bit of backstory of this version of SW here that is not really one of my headcanons and doesn't apply to any other of my universes tbh, so idk where it even came from, but it fit well… The Muse knows what she's doing, I guess

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The day following the sneak attack on the fortress felt eternal to Castaspella.

Around ten people had decided to stay on the Fright Zone, as servants of the fortress, while a dozen more chose to flee, find somewhere to stay in another kingdom, and fend for themselves if Mystacor tried to take them back.

Ten people didn’t cover the loses suffered, of course, not by a lot, but Shadow Weaver wasn’t concerned about that.

Castaspella, however, was *very* concerned.

She felt *so guilty*.

The only thing that eased her a little was learning that the apothecary, despite being exposed that night, had survived. In fact, they had been saved by the reanimated corpses in the gardens.

They were merely lucky…

Castaspella was thankful, yet didn’t feel any less responsible thinking about what had happened.

And it obviously showed because everyone kept telling her to rest and leave the cleaning to them.

But she refused.

Stubbornly diligent, she helped clean the blood off the floors and walls; she also took it upon herself to contact the families and friends of the victims, receive them, and arrange how the funerals would be.

She wanted to take this responsibility off Shadow Weaver's shoulders, so that the woman would focus on writing to Adora and Catra and get the truth of what had happened published on the newspaper as soon as possible.

However, that meant she inevitably would have to receive the partners of the short man whose name she could never ask…

They had arrived later that morning with a multitude of other people, looked quite lost, and remained near the back of the room. Castaspella didn't know who they were, yet their behaviour called her attention, since they didn't seem as eager as everyone else to speak to her…

Eventually, as she went through everyone before them, it became obvious who they were.

So, how should she refer to him?

Or should she try to ask them his name?

She didn't want to offend them, but… she also wanted to know his name.

—Alright. Then that's settled— the sorceress concluded, before sending off the mother of a gardener who would soon get her son's cremated remains. —And now there's just you two. Please, don't be shy. I'd like to… help you however I can— she called upon them, hesitating already.

—You must be Castaspella— the woman began. —I'm Arleen, and they are Oron. Our husband told us so much about you— she went on, tearing up. —I am- I can't believe…

Interrupted by her sobbing, she hunched over and Oron immediately reached out to support her.

—I can't believe it either… I wish it hadn't… happened— Castaspella admitted. —I owe him my life, so please let me do whatever I can now.

—Of course— Oron nodded. —We know there will be a funeral for everyone, and… we'd like to attend with our… kids.

—He had… *children*?— the sorceress gasped, covering her mouth and tearing up.

—You didn't know?— they asked back.

—He was quite overprotecting of them, so I can imagine he didn't really mentioned our kids at all — Arleen interceded, voice still broken.

But it didn't help the young woman in the least.

Still in shock, she uttered and apology and stumbled back a few steps before running away.

Arleen and Oron remained there, confused, unsure of what to do now.

Yet it wasn't long before Shadow Weaver herself showed up.

—Dark Lord— they both said, bowing.

—Ah… I see— she sighed. —Castaspella just sent me a distress signal to come here, and I can guess why.

—Did we do something…

—Not *you*— she interrupted Oron. —She has- Let's just say your husband's death was quite a shock for her. And, if I'm correct, she didn't know about his family, which… may have made things unbearable for her now.

—We… mentioned our kids, yes— Arleen admitted.

—Oh, of course— Shadow Weaver sighed. —Don't worry, I'll handle this for you. I believe he left you a letter with instructions for the day this came to happen.

—Ye-yes— Oron stammered, tearing up as they took out the letter. —That's part of what we had to discuss, but…

—The agreement with you is that one of our family must serve here at the Fortress— Arleen interrupted.

—True— she nodded.

—But his instructions say… we should- That-that we should try to make a new deal with you— she went on. —If it's possible, we-we rather pay some tribute or anything you may want, but…

—Well, his agreement with me was to live here, as my personal assistant, and return home to you for a set amount of hours a week that he could arrange as he pleased— the Dark Lord began. —If that kind of agreement isn't satisfactory for you…

—It isn't— Oron cried, unable to hold back. —Our children are *devastated*. They-they don't believe what happened. Neither of us can just leave them now, a-and we can't move in here to live either because of the same risks he was trying to protect us from!

—I understand— Shadow Weaver calmly said, raising a hand to stop him. —Which is why I was going to say I have a different proposal for you.

—What are the terms?— Arleen immediately asked, trying to look tough but barely hiding her tears.

—It's rather simple: I understand your kids are all above twelve years old, right?— she began. As they nodded, she went on —In that case, I want you both to bring them to the fortress, at least five days a week, for no less than eight hours, to learn a skill. Sorcery, fighting, or a craft. Anything they can do.

—Huh?

—I spoke to him about this once. He wanted them to be able to take care of themselves if he was ever gone. He wanted you *all* to be capable of going on *without* him— she explained. —Hence, I told him I would provide you the opportunity to manage that. Since you're adults, you can choose where or how to learn any skills, of course, but I promised to make sure, personally, that your children would be formed to their best capacity— she concluded.

—What if they- if they don't want to?— Oron asked.

—Just let them know that was what their father wanted. That they will make him proud. And if one day they wish to take his place here, they will have the means.

—But they would be in danger!— Arleen argued.

—I mean in the far future, when they are adults. I am sure there's a chance they may want to follow his steps. If they don't want to, that's fine, they will just have learnt a skill. But if they do want to join the Fortress, being trained in some way may prove indispensable.

As Shadow Weaver fell quiet and solely observed them, they both looked down to the ground, pensive. Eventually, Oron looked back at Arleen, took her hand, and teared up again.

—She's right. It would be best for our kids to… you know, learn a skill, become more capable… It- it may also keep their minds occupied and help them… get through this.

—I-I don't understand. Why- She couldn't protect him!— Arleen finally cried, after clearly holding it back for a long time. —I trusted- We trusted you with his safety!— she then yelled, looking at Shadow Weaver. —I-I…— she stammered, opening her eyes wide as she realized what she had done. —So-sorry. I didn't mean to…

—Yes, you meant to say that— Shadow Weaver interrupted. —And I'd rather you keep that fighting spirit, you hear me? All I propose is that you feed that same spirit within your children.

—Ca-can we discuss this with them?— Oron interceded. —We do-don't want to force them to do anything. I-if they refuse, we'll just come back and ask for a different proposal, and we'll accept it no matter what it is— they promised.

That was a very dangerous promise to make.

Shadow Weaver knew that well.

Which spoke volumes of how much they meant it.

—Very well— the Dark Lord accepted, joining her hands behind her back. —As for the rest of the instructions…

—To take the things from his room; there are some things prepared for us, it seems, and… cremation— Arleen managed to say, brushing away her tears.

—Then I'll have someone guide you both to his room. Preparations for the cremation of his body will be ready soon, and if you wish to bring your kids to the ceremony before the funeral, we can schedule it accordingly— Shadow Weaver told them.

—Perhaps just for the funeral— Oron considered. —When will it take place?

—Today at sunset. You will be given his remains after it's done.

—Alright— they sighed.

—Thank you, Dark Lord— Arleen sobbed.

But she didn't reply.

She didn't know what to say.

Hence, Shadow Weaver only watched them leave before returning to the former knights who were writing their testimonies.

As soon as the Dark Lord handed the courier her letter and a package with all the recounts of the attack, asking for them to deliver it post-haste, she decided to find Castaspella.

The way she had left and called her to help Arleen and Oron in her stead had been… a bit too sudden, which worried her when she recalled what Castaspella had once told her.

Namely, about that *other* source of her scars.

So it was no surprise when Shadow Weaver knocked on her door and got no reply from the young woman.

She could hear sobbing, however, so she had to be inside and conscious.

—Casta… Can I come in?

—No…— her voice faintly replied.

—Let me help you…

—Forget it— she insisted.

—Casta— she kept trying. —Did you do something? I need you to open the door… I won't scold you.

—You will…

—No. I swear I won't. But let me help you. And… heal you if needed.

There was silence for a long moment before the young sorceress finally dared to open the door.

Shadow Weaver's eyes went wide in shock as soon as she saw her face.

Her hand reached out to cup Castaspella's cheek, but the woman moved aside.

—Ju-just come in.

—Let me heal you.

—Fine…

Gently taking her hand, Shadow Weaver pulled her to sit on the bed together, and then carefully cleaned each scratch on her face and neck before closing the wounds with a healing spell. Right after, she took Castaspella's hands again, checked her nails, and used another spell to clean the skin under them.

—Would it be okay if we just clip these?

—I- Ye-yes— the young woman nodded, feeling a lump on her throat.

It took a bit, but finally they were done.

—Now, I need you to tell me what happened— the Dark Lord asked. —I have a bit of an idea, but I need you to explain yourself instead of making assumptions.

Castaspella's expression became tense. She struggled to speak, and to swallow, kept moving her hands nervously, and avoided looking back at Shadow Weaver.

—I-I… didn't… know… he-he had…

—Children?

Castaspella slowly nodded.

—I didn't even… kno-know his name!— she then sobbed, choking on her words. —A-and he-he talked to them… about me!

—Casta…— Shadow Weaver called, reaching for her shoulders. —Listen to me.

—No, no!

Shaking, the young woman refused to look back at the Dark Lord.

—His death was *not* your fault. Do you hear me?

—It was!

—No— Shadow Weaver severely insisted. —It was not. You do *not* deserve any kind of punishments for this. Not from anyone, including yourself.

—You don't know what I'm feeling— Castaspella sobbed, tearing up.

—I know.

Pulling her into a tight hug, the Dark Lord pondered whether to reveal a secret from her childhood.

Part of her was willing to let her know about this because she wanted so desperately to let Castaspella know she understood her pain, that she was not alone.

But another part feared the consequences of letting her know *this*.

—You don't- You-you are… basically their hero— the woman spoke, before she could decide. —I am the-the ha-harbinger of doom, or some-something…— she insisted, sniffing but at least posing no resistance to Shadow Weaver's embrace.

—You're not that. And I'm no hero either— the Dark Lord began. —I may be the one who saved you, at least partially, so *you* may see me as a hero. But…

—But-but what!? You-you keep all the-these people safe!

—And yet I *couldn't save almost anyone* last night— she reminded Castaspella, who only shrunk between her arms. With a long sigh, trying to stay calm, she began —Listen… When I was- When… I was a teen, I had two sisters.

—Huh?

—My baby sister was six. My older sister not even sixteen yet. And I was ten— Shadow Weaver went on. —Our father was a strict man, more on the tyrannical side. And our mother had died after her last birth.

—Your… broken lip?

—You may think he did that… And you'd be *wrong*— she replied, finally making Castaspella look up at her. —I never told you *how* my split lip related to my intolerance for physical abuse…

—You don't have to tell me.

—But I want to. I need you to know— Shadow Weaver clarified. —The split lip was caused by a multitude trying to lynch me… for killing my older sister— she revealed. Castaspella's eyes only widened, but no gasp or other form of surprise escaped her, so she went on —The one who stopped them from killing me, was Norwyn. And for the longest time, I resented him for it.

—What?— she uttered, her voice a whisper.

—I wanted to die, I *wanted* the people to kill me… After all, I didn't kill my sister for any reason other than… well, keeping my younger sister from being sold as a slave, and I don't mean the servant kind.

—Wait, but…

Taking a deep breath, the Dark Lord explained —My father hated our sisterhood. He hated that we didn't compete to best the others… He called us one day, asked me to knock down my older sister or he'd kick our youngest to the street. I refused. He insisted, and I kept refusing, so he made it even worse, until his order was to kill my older, or the youngest would be sold.

—And you…

—I didn't want to, but she begged me to save our sister, to kill her and protect our baby sis— Shadow Weaver went on. —The problem was that, after killing her, my father threw me to the streets yelling I was a murderer; people came to kick me to death, Norwyn stepped in.

—And your little sister?

The Dark Lord's expression was loud enough.

—I couldn't save either of them— was all she said.

—I'm so sorry, Bea— Castaspella let out, tearing up again and hugging her back now. —I shouldn't have said…

—You didn't know. Now you do.

—I think I understand why you told me. Thank you— she sniffed, looking up at her.

—Then say it— Shadow Weaver requested, holding Castaspella's chin up.

—I love you.

—So do I, my Little Sorceress— she replied, before kissing her briefly. —I'll make sure the preparations for the cremations and funeral are underway. You can stay here if you prefer.

—No, I-I'll help.

—Alright— the Dark Lord accepted. —Just take breaks whenever you need them.

—I will. Oh, and… uh, what… what was his name? If I talk to Arleen and Oron again, I… want to be prepared.

—Egon.

—Like… Like the sword?— Castaspella inquired, confused albeit letting a smile escape her lips.

—Indeed. That's why he was here. He was the sword protecting his family— Shadow Weaver nodded. —And he protected us too, to the very end.

Chapter End Notes

That's all for this week!!

Also, lemme promote over here the opening of the sign-ups for the spop anniversary Big Bang 2026!! :D

If anyone's interested in joining, just hit the link :) Writers and artists welcome!!

Next week, I promise this time, will be the final chapter for realsies, aaaaaand you may actually not like that it simply ends there (/v\) Ehe

THANKS FOR READING!!!

Chapter 13

Chapter Notes

Omgs… Ok, I totally *didn't* just rush this, no no, ofc not…

Yes, I did.
Kinda
I finished it earlier, then let it rest, then edited it, and I may have missed something, so I apologize…

ALSO this chapter is TERRIBLE
Omgs, but I still hope u enjoy this finale!! :D

See you at the end!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The courier did their job and delivered everything within an hour.

The girls pretty much yelled, indignant when they read the letter, and immediately went for Glimmer and Bow.

—This is… real!?— the Princess exclaimed, suddenly breathless. —My grandmother is *insane*.

—And that stack is to publish!?— Bow inquired, shocked.

—That's the idea— Catra nodded. —Obviously the newspaper isn't eternally large, so we should give these to the editor and let the team select fragments and whatnot. I think they can better decide how to go around posting this, maybe let the people consult the full testimonies if they prefer, I don't know…

—It's definitely a lot to post, but it's all very important— Adora agreed. —I'd say we give them copies of these, keep the originals, and… well, they can do whatever with the material, but we'll have the whole thing if they somehow twist the story.

—I don't think they will twist the story. I mean, Lonnie and Kyle handle edition, and there's no way that boy would agree to manipulating the story. He's too righteous— Glimmer pointed out. —As for Lonnie, well, she *did* take over as head of edition because of how biased the previous one was.

—Ugh, don't remind me. I heard Octavia took bribes, even— Catra scoffed. —Anyways, we… With Adora we would like to attend the funeral they are organizing in the Fright Zone, so if you could handle this…

—Of course, guys. We will— Bow promised. —But, uh, I think you should probably avoid Shadow Weaver… One thing are letters; going face to face…

—We don’t plan on talking to her. But we knew many of the people who died…— Adora explained, looking down.

—Then go ahead. I know you can handle yourselves— Glimmer encouraged them.

Evening arrived soon enough, with dark clouds and a faint burnt smell.

Adora and Catra remembered the last time they had attended such a funeral. The last time they had seen Hordak, and the same day they got permission to move to Salineas and study at the Alliance School.

They had had no reason to return at all during the past few years, and while they didn’t regret a thing, they certainly wished their return could have been under better circumstances.

Keeping in touch with Shadow Weaver had let them know their friends there were living happily, or at least, happier than before. Yet Catra couldn’t help but admit that a part of her wished to have been kept in the dark.

Adora and Catra knew Egon, they knew his family, his kids. Not knowing about it wouldn’t change the fact that he died, but a more selfish part of Catra simply wished to have avoided that pain overall…

Shaking her head, she followed Adora into the Fortress and all the way to the gardens, where they found a secluded corner from where to observe and pay respects.

The Dark Lord saw the girls arrive.

Just like she saw Arleen and Oron with their three kids…

She took notice of everyone.

Castaspella stood by her side, eyes down, expression forlorn.

The funeral would last a whole hour, the only rule was to keep silent, save for crying, of course, and everyone was welcome to arrive, stay, and leave whenever they felt like it.

Flowers could be brought, incense could be burnt.

Each could honour their dead as they pleased, as long as no one caused trouble.

Shadow Weaver made sure no one would dare.

After the funeral, people could stay to talk with others if so they pleased, or they could leave as soon as they received the ashes of their relatives or friends.

Hence, after a gloomy hour in silent mourning, the Dark Sorceress waved her hand, sealing the urns with the remains of every victim, and strengthened the torches’ light to conclude the funeral.

—Go— she then told Castaspella. —They probably want to speak to you too— she insisted, gesturing at Egon's family.

The young woman just gave her a look, in silent thanks, and walked away, taking deep breaths.

Shadow Weaver then handled the delivery of the urns, and continued to observe everyone.

Adora and Catra understandably stayed away from her while catching up with old friends.

Castaspella and Egon's family were talking with sad smiles and wet cheeks.

And the new members of the fortress… well, they looked both ashamed and relieved. They seemed to be offering help to everyone, remained respectful, and humble.

Eventually, the gardens were cleared out. People left, returned home, Adora and Catra went back to Salineas, and the servants of the Fortress cleaned up before retiring to sleep.

The last newspaper edition, a special evening edition, was delivered little after.

While Castaspella took a bath, Shadow Weaver barely skimmed over it and that was enough to make the Dark Lord smirk widely.

Hence, as soon as the young sorceress was out of the bathroom, she showed her the newspaper.

—This is real?

—Of course it's real!

—I can't believe it…— Castaspella sighed.

—Wasn't this what you wanted?

—I guess? I don't… know.

—What's making you doubt?— Shadow Weaver decided to ask, leading her to sit on the bed.

—Just… I… I suppose I didn't know what to expect— she uttered, setting the newspaper down next to her.

—I see…— the Dark Lord sighed. —Then…

—We- This was delivered to all of Etheria, so… I think we have to-to act now.

—Act? What do you think we should do?

—My mother will go insane, if she hasn't yet— Castaspella began. —There's a chance she will try to keep it all under wraps and pretend it's a lie, but there's also a great chance she will finally get rid of Norwyn for good. And of my father even, but he may have more time. So we *really* need to find Norwyn and get him out of Mystacor— she explained. —Can we open a portal? I didn't want to anger my mother before, but… they attacked first, so now I'm pissed, and since this came out, he's in danger, so…

—Casta, you should sleep— the Dark Lord interrupted.

—I can't— she insisted.

Holding each other's sight, there was a moment of silence until Castaspella's expression became unbearable.

—Well…— Shadow Weaver sighed, resigned. —I can't open a portal there, not without knowing Mystacor well enough. It should be you doing it.

—Can you help me? I'm not good with portals…

—*Yet*— she smirked. —You'll be with a little help.

It was quite late by the time Queen Akane received the news of the… most recent edition of Salineas School's newspaper.

She had managed to keep it *so well hidden*. She had managed to… *ignore* the utter failure of her generals… And now those little brats at school- How could it be that they got those written testimonies!?

Akane was furious. Shadow Weaver couldn't have that kind of power, could she?

How had she defeated everyone? How had she convinced the survivors to write the things that were published? And how had she gotten it all in the newspaper the same day!?

The Queen wanted to scream… but it wouldn't be proper there at the throne room.

She couldn't be seen losing her composure.

She knew it'd be taken as a sign of weakness, or rather, as some sort of confession.

But, of course, if she retired to her room, she'd be able to unleash her rage at her heart's content.

Except…

—Your Majesty?

—Tell me— she replied, hiding her annoyance.

—*Someone* wants to speak to you— her servant said.

The tone was suspicious enough for her to understand what it meant.

—I'll be there in a moment.

—The secluded garden, as usual.

As soon as the Queen nodded, the servant walked away, and she let out a deep sigh.

Only one person could call her that way, and it was none other than this *one* sorcerer who remained loyal to her.

So, of course, she attended at once and found him waiting in that small garden, the one where she had taken Micah before telling him where his sister was…

It was the perfect place to speak privately, wasn't it?

—What is it?

—Good evening to you too, your Majesty— he replied, not turning around. —I have unfortunate news.

—Do you?

—Norwyn is gone.

—*Excuse me*!?

—Unfortunate news, as I said…

—*How*!?— the Queen insisted.

—I perceived a portal opening down at the dungeons, and by the time I arrived, he was gone.

—That can't be.

—And yet, it happened— he smirked, finally turning to face her.

—If that's the case, then you have a new job— Akane hissed. —I expect you to know what to do.

—Certainly, your Majesty— he nodded, bowing deeply.

Meanwhile, the Dark Lord and Castaspella were rushing to take a very weak Norwyn into the infirmary in the Fortress, followed closely by Zacharias.

The anthropomorphic ram was covered in filth and dried blood. His horns were missing, he looked noticeably pale, and the women had both noticed in his eyes the faint glimmer of life left in him threatening to go out.

—I will need some help here with him— Zacharias admitted, while Shadow Weaver and Castaspella carefully laid him on a bed. —Can any of the new ones come help?

—I'll get them— Castaspella nodded, sniffing as she tried to hold back her tears. She could hardly breathe through the lump in her throat; seeing Norwyn so hurt, knowing it had been her mother who hurt him like that, and that it was her fault… It was too much for her. But she'd make it up to him, she'll get him help. Hence, as soon as she came across two of the new servants who had yet to go to bed but looked free enough, she stopped them. —We need your help!

—Are you alright?— one of them asked, noticing her stained clothes.

—I am, but… Norwyn isn't.

—You rescued the Head Sorcerer!?

—Yes, but he's…

—We'll be right there— they both interrupted, serious.

It wasn't long before they got Norwyn cleaned and properly bandaged, and finally, Castaspella and Shadow Weaver could rest for a bit, knowing he'd be fine.

—Casta— Shadow Weaver sighed, placing a hand on her shoulder. —Why don't you get changed?

—I- No, well, I can do that later.

—Why not now?

—I was thinking I should get the cure to my father. Before The Castle becomes enough of a mess that I could get caught if I try to return.

—Ah, right…— she sighed. —Then let's pick up the medicine and I'll help you again with the portal— the Dark Lord accepted.

By the time Micah arrived at Mystacor, the people were already… on the brink of attempting to burn down The Castle.

—What's going on here?— he muttered, making his way upstairs.

Among yelling and angry chanting, he eventually managed to arrive at the throne room, and his mother soon ushered him into "safety".

—Just stay with your father, make sure no harm comes to him, and I'll handle this mess the newspaper caused.

—But I came to speak to you about that— he argued.

—That will have to wait. You wouldn't want your poor father to be attacked by this crazy multitude, would you?

—No, Mother…— he sighed.

—Then go!— she insisted, closing the door to the bedroom as soon as he stepped inside.

Feeling defeated, and struggling within at the thought of having to confront his mother, Micah went to sit on the bed, at his father's feet, and stared at him with a gloomy look.

However, something shifted in the air suddenly, and his attention was immediately drawn towards a portal opening before the door.

—E-Esmeralda!?— he stammered, standing up. —What are you doing here!?

—Micah!? I-I don't have time— she replied, shaking her head. —We need to give him this— she then explained, approaching him.

—What is this!?

—A cure— she smiled, taking one of his hands and making him hold it. —He can… still be saved. I hope…

—But where did you get this!?

—Micah, I made it. I don't have time to explain…— she answered, looking back at the door, hearing the ruckus outside. —I must return before Mother comes in here. Just give Father this and *protect him*.

Without another word, Castaspella returned to the still-open portal, disappeared into it, and it immediately closed, leaving Micah with a choice.

Trust his sister, or trust his mother.

Castaspella was even covered in some dark filth that disturbingly resembled dried blood, but…

Maybe she was really trying to save him.

By the time Queen Akane returned to the bedroom where she had left her son, the King was conscious again.

—O-oh… You're- My Dear, you're awake!— she let out, hiding the chill that ran down her spine.

—Don't— he immediately stopped her. —Micah, don't listen to her.

—I know, Father— he nodded. —I'm sorry, but I can't do this anymore— he then told her. —I will give you one chance to admit everything you've done, to come clean, and to make up for the harm you've caused…

—Micah, what-what harm?— she stammered, pretending to be confused.

—Everything! My father, your *own* husband! My sister, your *own* daughter!

—I've done nothing…— she denied, looking away.

—Nothing *good*!— the King scoffed. —Micah, don't ever let her close to Esmeralda ever again— he ordered.

—I don't plan to— he accepted. —And I believe… we should let the people of Mystacor properly judge her for everything she's done, don't you think?— he then commented. —Sending people to die on a furtive attack to the Fright Zone. Attempting to murder the King, forcing the Princess to escape… Who knows what else…

—Certainly— the King nodded, still in bed, but with a fierce look.

Far from afraid, Queen Akane laughed.

She simply laughed, maniacally, dropping the façade.

—You want to… To do *what* exactly?— she further laughed. —Expose me in some way? Put me on trial?— she mocked her son. —You wouldn't *dare*.

—I don't care if you are my mother. *Because* you are, it is my responsibility to…

—To what!?— she interrupted. —You won't do *anything*— she defied him, approaching. —Because the moment you so much as try to "expose" me, I will make sure to show the same treatment to you wife and daughter.

—You wouldn't— he breathed out, suddenly pale.

—I would and your pretty little wife knows as much— his mother insisted. —Why do you think she sent dear Glimmer so far away to study?

—To… keep her safe… *from you*.

—Oh, my Dear, I can hardly believe you're *my* son… With how slow you are, you're clearly your father's son— she scoffed. —So go ahead, try to warn your dear wife, try to protect your sister and your daughter… You don't even know what I'm planning to do, and what I've already *done*.

Meanwhile, back in the Fright Zone, the news about Norwyn's rescue and current state were spreading like wildfire. From the little room where they were, Castaspella and Shadow Weaver could hear people talking about it.

It was no surprise, of course, but still, the Dark Lord was impressed.

However, as soon as her attention returned to the young woman, she noticed her distress.

—What is it?

—I-I just realized… I don't know if- Ho-how am I supposed to know if the cure worked!?

—Calm down. Give it some time and then we'll check on your father— Shadow Weaver suggested. —Why don't we return to see how Norwyn is doing?

—Yes, that could be a good idea— Castaspella agreed, following her outside. However, as they walked past the kitchen, she asked —Should we get him something to eat?

—Maybe. Why don't you ask the cooks to whip something up and send it to the infirmary?

—I will— she smiled, returning to the kitchen. Yet, as soon as she pushed the door opened, she froze in place. —Oh, uh… There's no one here— she informed.

—Ah… right. The two helping at the infirmary were to replace the cooks— Shadow Weaver realized.

—Then I'll prepare something myself. Don't worry.

—Alright. I'll go check on Norwyn in the meantime— the Dark Lord accepted, nodding at her. —Take your time.

—I'll be quick!

With that, Castaspella walked into the kitchen, closed the door behind her, and familiarized herself with the place before getting to work.

Once she put everything inside a pot with water and over a medium fire, she rested back against a counter and let out a sigh.

Then she noticed the door to the kitchen was now open.

Confused but not wanting the smell of food to spread all over the halls, she went to close it, yet was stopped by a familiar hand.

—There you are…

—Oh, so-sorry. I took too long after all, didn't I?

—Maybe…— Shadow Weaver replied, walking into the kitchen. —Soup?

—Yes. He probably was starved for a long time, so solid food won't do for now, I guess…

—Smart— she smirked, turning back to face Castaspella. —I'll need you to follow me now.

—Can't it wait until I deliver the soup?

—I'll get someone else to deliver it— the Dark Lord dismissed her.

—But…— she began, yet interrupted herself seeing Shadow Weaver walking away. —Bea, please — she begged, stopping her by the arm.

—I'm asking you to come with me, don't you trust me? We'll be back by the time it's done, if that makes you feel better…

—I'm not in the mood to keep diverting my attention, alright?— Castaspella admitted. —Let me focus on Norwyn now, and then help me see my father. Once I know they are both safe, I'll go with you wherever you want.

Shadow Weaver stood there for a moment, seemingly pensive.

Eventually, she turned around, took one of the young woman's hands, and told her —Unfortunately, it will have to be now. Just follow me for a moment, then we'll return. Do you trust me or not?

—Of course I trust you— Castaspella assured her, holding her hand between hers. —But… I told you. I won't do anything else now— she sighed, letting go of her hand.

—Come on, do me this favour. You know I love you…

Castaspella froze in place.

It was… like a sudden rush of electricity running through her whole body.

It was a visceral feeling deeply ingrained within her, making all her scars feel freshly opened again.

Instinctively she took a step back.

—Wha-what?

Then another step back.

And another.

Shadow Weaver moved closer, causing her to keep backtracking until she bumped against a table.

—Just follow me for a moment, it's all for you, because I love you— she insisted, stepping into Castaspella's personal space.

Before she realized it, the young sorceress' hand was on the table, reaching for anything there may be, and soon… the kitchen knife was buried deep into the Dark Lord's abdomen, blood oozing out and staining Castaspella's hand.

However, as she stepped back, the knife still there, Castaspella saw something odd.

That was *not* Shadow Weaver.

"She" soon changed into a different shape, and a man in robes appeared on the ground, still bleeding profusely. Castaspella wasn't sure at first, but then she recognized him.

Why *him*!?

Before she could do anything, the real Dark Lord appeared on the door.

—Casta!?

—I'm sorry…— she barely managed to say, her voice almost gone.

—What happened?— Shadow Weaver asked, approaching her slowly.

—He looked like you. A-and your voice… Everything.

—And you… realized it wasn't me?

—No…— Castaspella cried. —But "she" said "I love you" and I *told you* not to say that, and…

—I know…— she nodded, finally daring to reach for her and pull her into a hug. Looking back at the dying man, she snickered and whistled. —You certainly did a number on him. I'm glad I've never even teased you with those phrases…

—I'm so sorry…— the young sorceress cried, holding onto her tightly.

—Don't be. I told you to keep yourself *safe*. If you felt threatened, even if he was posing as me, I am *glad* you acted— Shadow Weaver insisted. —Now, we should go.

—Wait, the-the soup for…

—Don't worry, I was bringing you help— she pointed out, making Castaspella notice the two new servants on the door. —You, get the soup to the infirmary. And you, either dispose of the body yourself or look for someone willing to do it.

—Yes, Dark Lord— they both replied, bowing slightly.

Just as Shadow Weaver took Castaspella away, Queen Akane dismissed the vision of the Fortress that took her so much effort to conjure properly.

—She's insane— she let out, unable to believe her daughter had just killed the sorcerer while he looked like the Dark Lord. —I'm- I can't possibly…— she stammered, voice trailing off as she realized just how traumatized Castaspella is, how dangerous she can be, and how not even the Dark Lord would be safe.

A moment later, once the women reached Shadow Weaver's room, they went directly to the basin.

—Why won't you tell me who he is?

—Because you'd want to revive him just to kill him yourself— Castaspella explained.

—He did something to you…

—And it's all in the past. I never wanted- Alright, I *wanted to* yet I never thought I would *actually* kill him, but it's done now— she insisted.

—Alright. Let's check on your father now, and then you can relax, hopefully— the Dark Lord sighed.

Casting the Pulse spell, images of The Castle in Mystacor appeared on the basin.

The King was on his feet, he looked in good shape already, and a bunch of knights followed him.

—Where is he going with all those men?

—Great question— Shadow weaver admitted.

—Oh, I know those doors…— Castaspella then realized, as the vision showed them the knights charging and trying to open a pair of sturdy decorated doors. —It's my mother's private room.

After a couple of tries, they finally forced the door open, and as soon as they saw the knights swarm her, the young sorceress dismissed the spell.

Chapter End Notes

Alright!! That was it for this fic! :D

Sorry… <("^_^)

Etto, so, yeah, I did a few things here, and I'm… not in a good mental place rn, so I didn't really… have much energy to finish this, but I did have notes, and this was what I wanted to do, and it turned out longer than expected, and it took me more time than initially intended, but at least now u know, Norwyn is safe, Casta's father is safe, Akane will get what she deserves, and… that's it, I guess :)

So, thank you very much for reading all this time, for following this story, and I really hope u enjoyed :D

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!